THE INNER HORIZON



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Volume III: Fables from Tarel



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Volume III: Fables from Tarel

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These thirty tales are drawn from the complete work The Inner Horizon and are reproduced here in their reading order, from origin to end, by way of the bonds between them.

The illustrations are drawn from the illustrated edition of the same work.

Set in Source Serif Pro.

To those who went without warning
and left their hollow in the archive.

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THE WORK IN FOUR VOLUMES

The Inner Horizon is one work told four times.

Its premise is a game with a single rule. Suppose that consciousness has the structure of an event horizon, the boundary of a Hawking micro black hole, and follow the supposition wherever it leads. It is a thought experiment, and the work never claims more for it. Where the idea lights something up, the work says so. Where it breaks, the work says that too.

A question like this will not keep to one register. It changes as it passes from physics to grief, from grief to a film, from a film to a kitchen at dawn. So the work was written in four voices, and each voice became a volume.

Volume I, Essay. The argument itself: the hypothesis, built chapter by chapter, and the point where it stops.

Volume II, Topological Readings. The hypothesis put to work on things that were made without it: novels, films, paintings, a football match.

Volume III, Fables from Tarel. The same idea told as short narratives, in and around a city that learned to live with the water that leaves.

Volume IV, Echoes at the Edge. The same idea in the language of feeling, as poems.

The volumes are independent. Each can be read alone and in any order, and none asks you to finish another first. Together they say one thing four times, and what changes from one telling to the next is where the weight falls.

This volume

This is the third volume. The essay explains; the stories happen. Its thirty tales, many of them set in or around Tarel, carry the same ideas into particular lives. A boy learns to measure time. A luthier builds instruments for people who have lost the way to each other. A house breathes.

They give the idea a tone the essay cannot reach, the tone of lives with names, rooms, weather and mistakes. Where the essay proposes, the story shows, and what the story shows it leaves unconcluded. An archivist's note opens the volume. After it, each tale works alone and can be entered anywhere.

THE INNER HORIZON

Stories

The Archivist's Note

These stories prove nothing.

They begin with a question —what happens inside when something emerges, endures, and leaves— and instead of trying to answer it, they circle it: birth, childhood, memory, love, desire, the bond, loss, sleep, grief, deterioration, harm, companionship. Not all angles lead to the same place. Some lead nowhere in particular, and that too is an answer.

There is an order —the one found in the table of contents— but each story works alone, like the knots of a net that can be read from any point.

The archivist takes notes and leaves hollows. The hollows are part of the archive.

Closing Note

Tarel and the one who remains are the same experiment told from two extremes: the water that leaves and what remains when it is no longer there. In between, and around them, all the other variations on the same question.

The question does not have a single answer. It has many small, partial answers, contradictory among themselves. That too is an answer.


TAREL

THE HABIT OF WATER

The water began to recede without warning.

There was no warning, there was no drought. In Tarel, speaking was always too late: things happened first, stayed after, and only with time became history.

The city floated on a brackish lagoon so ancient that no one remembered a beginning. Wooden houses, worn ropes, joints made with patience. Children learned the sway before the names of the streets; they knew how to return before knowing how to leave. To come home was a verb: a repeated action, a small habit of the body. The water was neither a background nor a landscape. It was the habit itself.

I was an archivist: I watched slowly what did not yet ask for a name.

—This wasn't here before —said Kema one morning, pointing to the dark edge left beneath her house—. The water knows.

—What does it know?

—When to let go... and when to stay.

I wrote it down, not knowing under which category of the archive to file it. It was not the last time someone gave me an exact answer to a question I did not know I had asked badly.

The water receded without haste. It did not tear away: it took its leave. Rotted piers. Mooring rings embedded in mud. Marks of past levels that no one wanted to read as prophecy. It was a guest who gathers their things while you sleep and leaves the room ready for someone who will not arrive.

In the archive lived two tales about Tarel, and I never chose between them. One said the city had always floated. The other, that we fled toward the water after a war, or after a thirst so old it no longer hurt. In both appeared the same word, written with different strokes: **home**.

I spent the following days noting what the retreat had uncovered: an anchor with no boat, a wooden bowl swollen with old water, three steps that had never led to any door. The archive grew more in that drought than in any other year of my trade.

Then, one night, without warning, without signs, the water of Tarel returned.

In the morning the inhabitants found the shore where it had always been. The same mud. The same stones. The same line of salt on the low walls.

No one could say if the water had brought anything with it.

No one could say if it had left anything behind.



THE THIEF OF INTERIORS

It was said of him that he could open anything.

It was not idle boasting; it was a simple statement of fact. Doors that had been sealed for generations, chests whose owners had died without opening them, boxes within boxes within boxes: everything yielded sooner or later to his hands, which knew how to listen to what a mechanism wanted before the mechanism itself knew it was saying it. He did not steal out of greed. He stole because he could not bear for something to be closed while he was on the outside.

He was told of a box at the end of a house at the end of a city at the end of a road. It was said that inside lay a treasure no thief had ever reached, not because the box was stronger than the rest, but because it had seven locks, and each was of a different kind, and none opened with what had opened the last.

He went.

I. The first lock

The first lock was of force.

It was the one everyone expected, the one any thief knows how to force: a mechanism of metal and resistance that yields when subjected to more pressure than it was designed to withstand. The thief studied it for a night, applied his iron at the exact angle, and the lock surrendered with the dry sound of things that only knew how to say no until someone insists enough.

He smiled. If they were all like this, it would be a short night.

They were not all like this.

II. The second lock

The second lock was of patience.

There was nothing to force: it was a mechanism that only opened if turned slowly, so slowly that any haste jammed it back to the beginning. The thief, accustomed to swift dexterity, had to learn something else. He spent three days turning a wheel one degree per hour, undoing an afternoon's work with a single tremor, starting over again. On the third day, his hands had learned not to want to arrive. The lock opened when he ceased to be in a hurry to open it.

It was not the same as the first. The first demanded what he had in excess. This one demanded something he did not know he lacked.

III. The third lock

The third lock was of silence.

It jammed with noise. Any sound—the scrape of a tool, his own breath, his heartbeat if heard too loudly—closed it. The thief had to quiet himself in a way he had never needed to before. He learned to breathe without his breathing being heard. He learned to be without making the noise of being. And in that silence, for the first time in years, he heard things his trade had always masked: that his hands trembled even though he did not tremble, that there was an old exhaustion beneath his dexterity. The lock opened when there was no longer anyone around his hands making a noise.

IV. The fourth lock

The fourth lock was of renunciation.

It had a simple and cruel trap: it held two latches that had to be opened at the same time, and he only had two hands, and to reach the second

latch he had to let go of the tool with which he had opened the three previous locks. His father's tool. The one that had made him a thief. He had to let it fall into the well that opened beneath the box, with no guarantee that there would be anything on the other side of the gesture.

He held it for a long time.

He let it go.

He heard it fall, and heard it not hit bottom, and the lock opened with the hand he now had free.

V. The fifth lock

The fifth lock was of memory.

It asked for a name. Not just any name: the mechanism only yielded to the name of someone the thief had loved and left behind for his trade. There were several. He chose the one that weighed on him the most, said it aloud in that empty house, and hearing himself say it was worse than letting go of the tool, because the tool fell and that was that, but the name, instead, returned.

The lock opened. He stayed for a while with the name in his mouth, which did not close as easily as the latch.

VI. The sixth lock

The sixth lock had no keyhole.

The thief searched for it everywhere: there was no slot, no wheel, no latch, nothing his hands knew how to interrogate. He spent an entire day running his fingers over a smooth surface that offered no way in. And he understood, slowly, that this lock could not be opened from the

outside. That the only way past it was to stop trying to open it: to accept that there was a part of that box that could not be accessed, that had to be crossed without forcing, by trusting. He withdrew his hands. He stood still before the smoothness. And the smoothness, when it ceased to be besieged, opened on its own, the way some things open only when one gives up trying to open them.

One remained.

VII. The seventh lock

The seventh lock opened with a bare hand.

It asked for no tool, no patience, no silence, no renunciation, no name, no trust. It asked only that he place his open palm upon it—the palm of the thief, the one that had forced so many doors—and wait. The thief placed his hand. He felt, beneath the skin, something beating the way living things beat. And for an instant, before the end, he had the certainty that on the other side of that final sheet of metal there was no object. That whatever the house guarded behind seven locks was not a thing that could be taken out and carried away.

He pressed his palm down.

The lock yielded.

And the box disappeared.

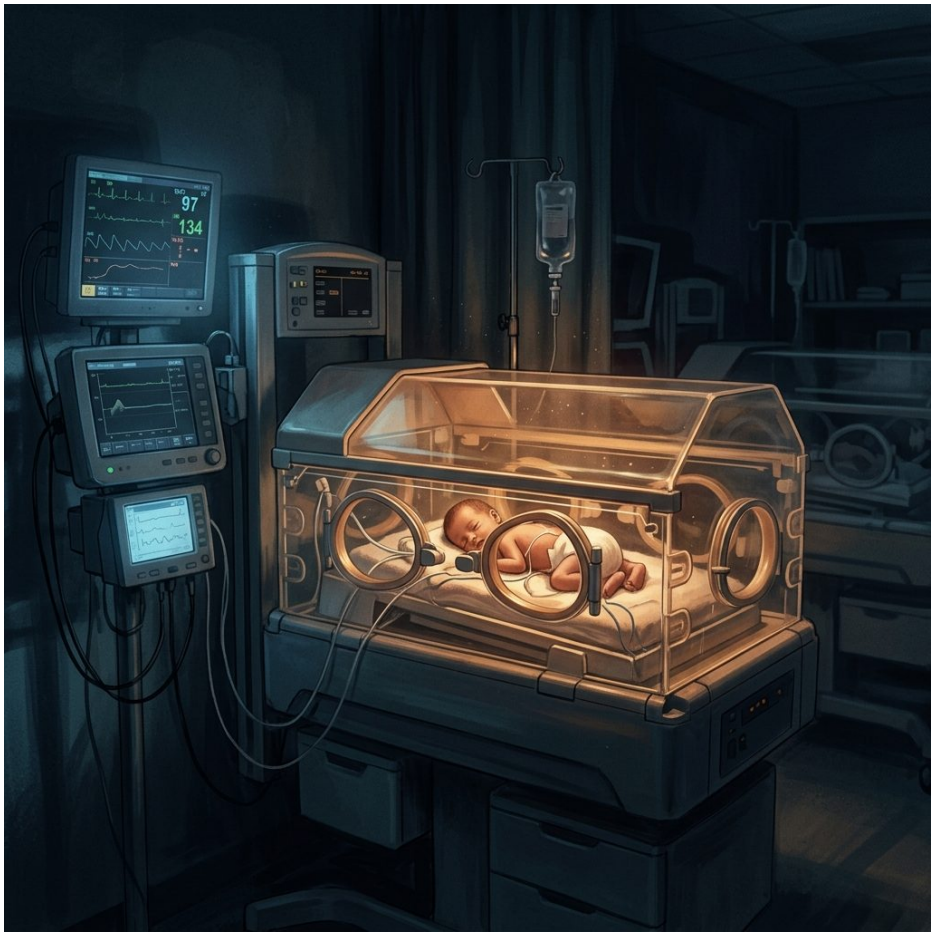
It did not open: it disappeared. In the exact instant the final frontier surrendered, the entire box—the metal, the seven defeated locks, whatever might have been inside—ceased to be, as if it had never been. No hollow remained in the air. No mark remained on the table. There was nothing left to steal, because there was no longer an inside from which to take it.

The thief stood with his palm open over the spot where the box had been.

He did not shout. He did not curse. He stood very still, as he had before the sixth lock, and understood—without words, the way one understands things that cannot be said—why it had disappeared.

He lowered his hand.

He left the house at the end of the city at the end of the road with empty hands, which in some cities is the only honest way to return from certain places.


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THE BUBBLE THAT DID NOT ANNOUNCE ITS CLOSING

Dr. Elena Valls had spent fifteen years waiting for something she did not know how to name.

It was not a clinical finding. It was not an observable moment on any monitor, any blood marker, any growth curve. It was rather the sensation that at some point—at some specific and probably unrepeatable point—a system that was processing signals began to have the experience of processing them. That the shift between one state and the other existed. That she might recognize it if she were looking at the right moment.

She had read the papers on the subject. She knew the consensus was provisional, that neonatal consciousness was disputed territory, that the available evidence was indirect. She knew all of that. She kept waiting all the same, with the patience of someone searching for something whose existence she cannot guarantee.

She was a neonatologist. She spent a lot of time looking at very small babies in incubators. She had material.

The night shift on March 14 began without incident.

Three premature babies in incubators: two at thirty-two weeks, stable, with a good prognosis. One at thirty weeks, who had been in the unit for eight days and who was called—in the files and in Elena's head—the Ferrán boy, although his name was Martí. Thirty weeks. Appropriate weight for his gestational age. Minor respiratory problems that were

resolving. No detected neurological complications.

Elena did the eleven o'clock rounds and checked the logs. Everything in order. She sat in the chair next to Martí's incubator because it had the best light for reading, not for any specific reason, and opened an article on her tablet.

Twenty minutes later, she looked up.

Martí had his eyes open.

That was not unusual. Premature babies at thirty weeks already have pupillary responses, they already move their eyes, they already respond to light stimuli. Elena knew this. She had seen it hundreds of times.

But there was something in the way Martí was looking that she could not immediately classify.

It wasn't that he was looking *at* her—newborns do not have voluntary fixation, they do not coordinate in that way. It was something different and harder to describe. It was that the quality of the gaze had changed in some subtle way, like when a room you have been working in changes temperature and it takes you a moment to realize it has changed.

She leaned toward the incubator.

Martí still had his eyes open. His pupils responded to the light. The vitals on the monitor showed nothing out of range.

Elena stayed there, leaning over, looking at him, for a time she did not measure.

The duty nurse, Raquel, walked behind her at one in the morning.

—Is everything alright? —she asked.

—Yes —Elena said—. Just looking.

Raquel looked at the incubator, then at Elena, and continued her rounds without asking anything else. It was the kind of answer Elena gave when she didn't want to explain something, and Raquel had been in the unit enough years to recognize it.

Elena looked back at Martí.

The baby's eyes were already closed.

Later that same night, she tried to reconstruct exactly what she had seen.

She had seen nothing quantifiable. There had been no recordable event. The vitals had been normal, the passive EEG worn by the babies in the unit had shown no significant change. What she had perceived was something on the order of subjective experience, which was precisely the problem: she was looking for a sign of subjective experience using her own subjective experience as her only instrument, and that instrument had obvious and documented limitations.

It was possible that she had projected. It was the most economical explanation.

It was also possible that she had not.

She wrote in the notebook she kept for informal clinical notes: *Martí Ferrán, 30 weeks + 8 days. 1:23 AM. Eyes open approximately 4-6 min.*

Quality of gaze: indefinable. No correlate on monitor. Then, below it, with another pen and in smaller handwriting: *When is that?*

She added nothing else because she had nothing else to add.

Martí was discharged at sixteen weeks.

Elena was at the discharge meeting, which was routine for premature babies of that gestational age. The parents—the father tall, quiet; the mother with eyes reddened from a crying that could have been out of relief or exhaustion or both at once—listened to the instructions regarding follow-up, room temperature, warning signs. The mother asked good, specific questions, the kind of questions that indicate someone has been reading and thinking. The father took notes on his phone.

Elena explained what needed to be explained. She answered the questions. She signed the documents.

Before they left, the mother turned to her and said:

—Thank you for being with him.

Elena started to say something—the usual, the correct thing—and then she didn't say it. She nodded. The mother had already turned toward the door.

She did not know why she hadn't said it. The usual thing was also true.

She saved a photo on her computer desktop. It was a file photo, not a personal one, taken during one of the control rounds: Martí in the incubator, cables and monitors all around, his face wrinkled and small. It was not a particularly good photo. She saved it anyway.

She looked at it sometimes, without any concrete purpose. Not with nostalgia and not with certainty. With something more akin to the sensation of having a question that has found its exact shape, though not its answer.

The question was this: at what moment, if there was a moment, had there begun to be someone in that incubator?

Not *when*: that could be tracked, more or less, in weeks and in cortex. But something that came before. The instant the incubator ceased to contain a system and began to contain Martí.

She had no answer. She had spent fifteen years without one, and she kept looking.

There is a version of this story in which Elena, on the night of March 14, sees something definitive. In which the moment takes shape and the monitors confirm it and she knows, with the specific certainty of real findings, that this is what she had been waiting for.

That version would be more satisfying as a story.

This is the one that happened: she saw something she could not measure, she wrote it down, she went home at seven in the morning, slept for five hours, and returned for the afternoon shift. Martí was fine. His vitals, normal.

What Elena took home that night—and the following nights, and many nights after—was not certainty. It was something more akin to what an archivist feels when correcting a map without yet knowing what city will lie on the other side of the correction. That something changed. That the change was real even if it did not yet have coordinates.

That perhaps that was enough for now.

In the notebook, beneath the vitals and the hours, the question was still there, written with the smaller pen: *When is that?* Fifteen years later, she still could not answer it with the larger one.



THE BOY WHO LEARNED TO MEASURE TIME

The summer I was eleven lasted longer than the others.

Not that the calendars lied. June, July, August: the same ninety days as always. But inside those ninety days there was something adults did not have, a density, a way of not ending, which I didn't know how to name back then and which now, looking back from my late forties, I recognize for what it was: time that took a long time to be spent.

We lived on a street of low houses with gardens that bordered one another without fences between them. Mr. Montserrat was eighty-four years old and had an olive tree's shadow that took up his entire backyard. He spent his afternoons in a wooden chair beneath the olive tree, reading or not reading, with the book open on his lap anyhow. He was the kind of person who learns to distinguish between sitting doing nothing and just sitting. That summer, for reasons I no longer quite remember, I decided he was the right person to ask certain things.

—How long does summer last? —I asked him one Tuesday.

He looked up from his book.

—Ninety days —he said.

—No. How long it lasts.

He looked at me for a while. Then he said:

—For me, less than before.

That was not what I wanted to know, but it was the right answer. I understood that later.

That summer I had invented a system of measurement.

Not with a watch. The watch measured hours, and the hours of summer were elastic in a way the watch did not recognize. My system used other units: the time from when you went out to the street until your mother called you for lunch. The time of a shadow crossing the patio. The time of an ant going from the flowerpot to the curb, which depended on whether the ant was carrying a load or not.

I filled a notebook with these measurements. I gave them names: shadow-time, ant-time, time-waiting-for-something-to-arrive. I had no conversion system between them. There was no need: each one measured something different, just as meters and kilos measure different things even though both are things that fit into a number.

What I discovered, without fully understanding it, was that August afternoons held many shadow-times inside them. More than June afternoons. Not because the shadows were longer —June has the shortest shadows of the year— but because in August the shadows moved more slowly. Or so it seemed to me. Or the time in which I watched them was thicker.

I didn't write it down in the notebook because I didn't know how. But I remembered it.

Mr. Montserrat taught me a game that had no name.

It consisted of sitting beneath the olive tree with closed eyes and waiting for something to happen. Nothing in particular. Just waiting.

—How long do we wait? —I asked the first time.

—As long as it takes —he said.

That irritated me a little because I wanted a measurable answer. But I sat down anyway on the ground, which in August smelled of dry earth and something I wouldn't know how to identify now, but which back then was the most normal smell in the world.

What happened the first time was that a bird landed on the lowest branch of the olive tree. I could hear it moving, its small weight making the wood creak. I didn't see it: my eyes were closed. But I listened to it move for what seemed like a long time, and then I heard it leave, and then there was silence, and the silence also lasted.

—How long did it last? —I asked Mr. Montserrat.

—How long did it seem to you?

—A long time.

—Then it lasted a long time.

He didn't say anything else. We both just sat there quietly for a while, me trying to make the bird's silence —the one that was no longer there— last a little longer.

My mother used to say that time flies when you are older.

I would ask her sometimes, during those long summer after-dinner hours that the adults stretched out with coffee and conversation while I tried to slip away: how long did summer last when you were eleven? She would say she didn't remember well, but that it seemed to her it lasted longer. That summers now went by fast, and the ones back then

did not.

—Why?

—Because when you're older there are too many things to do.

I was left with the question more than the answer, which is what usually happens when you ask a grown-up something like that. Besides, I had a problem with that reason: Mr. Montserrat didn't have many things to do —he spent his afternoons in the wooden chair, he had reduced everything to that— and it didn't last for him the way it did for me either.

I didn't find the reason. Or I found it once and then couldn't get it back. That also happens with certain things.

That summer there was an afternoon storm that wasn't supposed to happen.

The clouds arrived suddenly at five o'clock, when there were still three hours of daylight ahead, and the sky turned the color it turns when summer pretends it knows how to do autumn. I was in Mr. Montserrat's garden. The wind smelled of wet earth before a single drop fell.

—It's going to rain —I said.

—I know —he said.

—Should we go inside?

He didn't move. He stayed in the wooden chair looking at the olive tree, which was moving its branches in a specific way I had never seen. As if the tree also knew what was coming and was waiting for it

with a posture that wasn't exactly fear, but wasn't calm either.

The rain arrived hard, all at once, the way it liked to arrive in August. We both got wet. Mr. Montserrat didn't seem to mind particularly. Neither did I, since I was already there.

It lasted ten minutes. Then the sun returned as if nothing had happened.

I didn't write that afternoon down in the notebook. There was no need: some things are kept somewhere else.

Mr. Montserrat died in November of that year.

My mother told me one afternoon, without preamble. He knew it, I suppose. Those who spend their afternoons looking at the sky with that specific calm usually know.

The olive tree remained there. That happens with olive trees.

For his game I have neither a name nor a definition. Only the memory of having my eyes closed beneath a branch, with the August heat clinging to my arms, waiting for something to happen without knowing what. And the sound of the bird moving. And then the silence of the bird that was no longer there.

And that both of them, while it lasted, lasted a long time.

Now I am in my late forties and summers last as long as they last.

Sometimes, in August, I look for a shadow and close my eyes for a moment. Something doesn't always happen. When it does, it lasts as long as it seems to me to last, which sometimes is a little and

sometimes is more than I expected.

I don't name it, I don't measure it, I don't carry the notebook with me. But somewhere in a drawer in my head that old system is still there, waiting: one more shadow-time, unrecorded.



THE LUTHIER'S SHOP

I. The One Who Entered Backwards

The first time Marta entered the shop, she did so backwards. Not in an elegant or calculated way. She simply pushed the door with her shoulder because she was carrying too many things in her arms and didn't want to drop any. She entered like that, facing the street, and then turned around and saw the Luthier sitting behind the counter with a piece of sandpaper in his hand and the face of someone who has spent the whole morning waiting for exactly this.

—Is this the place? —Marta asked.

—Depends —said the Luthier.

—They told me you made special instruments.

The Luthier placed the sandpaper on the counter with care, as if the sandpaper had its own opinions about where to rest.

—I make instruments —he said—. The adjective is supplied by the client.

Marta looked around. The shop smelled of wood and something harder to name, like when it rains on dry earth. There were instruments on the walls, on the shelves, on the tables. None had a price tag.

—Can I ask you something first? —Marta said.

—You have entered my shop backwards —said the Luthier—. You have already asked me everything important.

He stood up, took a measuring tape from the drawer, and came around the counter.

—Who is it for? —he asked.

—For me —Marta said—. And for someone else.

The Luthier nodded as if that were exactly what he expected. He began to measure. Not Marta—that would have been strange. He measured the space between Marta and the door. Then the space between Marta and the nearest shelf. Then he stopped, put away the tape, and looked at her.

—How long have you two been without knowing how to speak? —he asked.

Marta opened her mouth. She closed it. She counted mentally.

—About three years —she said.

—Good —said the Luthier—. That is manageable.

He returned to the workshop without explaining what was manageable or why the opposite would not have been.

Three weeks later, the Luthier called her. Marta entered facing forward this time. The instrument was on the counter. It was small. Unexpectedly small. It did not seem capable of filling three years.

—It doesn't have to fill it —said the Luthier—. It only has to provide the starting frequency.

Marta took it with both hands. Something in the weight—or in the temperature of the wood, or in the exact way it fit between her fingers—produced a sensation she could not name until the next day: it was recognition. Not of the instrument, which she had never seen. Of

the rhythm the instrument was going to sustain.

The Luthier watched her leave from the counter. He picked up the sandpaper. He went back to work. On the table he had a notebook with a single line: "What the water leaves behind when it recedes does not always have a name." He had written it years ago. He didn't remember why.

Three years is manageable.

II. The Notebook of Grievances

The second client arrived with a list. Not a list of instruments. A list of grievances. Twenty years of grievances, handwritten in a spiral notebook that he placed on the counter with the solemnity of someone presenting evidence before a court.

—I want an instrument to forget someone —he said.

The Luthier looked at the notebook without opening it.

—Is he alive? —he asked.

—He died six months ago.

—And yet you bring it in writing?

The client looked at the notebook as if he had just realized what he had done.

—I have been keeping it in writing for twenty years —he said—. Habit.

The Luthier nodded. He stood up, came around the counter, and began to walk slowly around the client. He didn't measure him. He just walked. The client followed his movement with his eyes, somewhat uncomfortable.

—What did he do? —asked the Luthier.

—Excuse me?

—Your neighbor. What exactly did he do that bothered you?

The client opened his mouth. He closed it. He pointed to the notebook.

—It's all in there.

—I prefer you tell me.

There was a pause.

—Music until two in the morning. Four or five times a week during the first years. Then less, but never entirely. The garbage bags on the landing, always the day before collection. The dog. The weekend visitors who parked in my spot. The disputes with the homeowners' association, which he always managed to wriggle out of. The noise of the chair—he had a wooden chair, on parquet, and he dragged it every morning at exactly a quarter past six.

The Luthier listened to all this without interrupting.

—And now? —he asked when the client finished.

—Now... I still hear the chair. At a quarter past six. Even though he is no longer there. Even though the apartment is empty.

—Of course —said the Luthier.

—Of course? —The client frowned—. That is not normal.

—It is completely normal. The problem is not memory. The problem is that you have spent twenty years building a very precise model of that man. You know exactly how he reacted. What made noise. How he

parked. How he moved in the morning. That model does not need him to be alive to keep functioning.

The client stared at him.

—And you can turn it off?

The Luthier returned behind the counter.

—I don't have instruments for forgetting —he said—. I never have.

—Then what are yours for?

—To connect. To process what remains of someone in the reservoir. To give the model a place to go instead of continuing to run on empty.

—Is that different from forgetting?

—Completely different —said the Luthier—. To forget is to erase. What I offer you is closer to resolving.

—Do you know the difference between a ghost and a memory? —asked the client.

The Luthier thought.

—Ghosts do not know they are dead —he said.

—Exactly. Mine does. That is the worst part. He is still there, dragging the chair, and we both know he shouldn't be.

The Luthier opened a drawer the client had not seen before. He took out something small, without an immediately recognizable shape. He placed it on the counter next to the notebook of grievances.

—This one does not connect with anyone —he said—. It connects with what comes after someone. It is different.

—Does it work?

—Depends on what you understand by working. It will not make you forget the chair. But you might stop hearing it as a threat.

The client looked at the object for a while. Then he picked it up.

—How much?

The Luthier named a price. The client did not protest, which said something about how long he had been searching. When he left, the Luthier put the spiral notebook away in the drawer. He had not opened it. He never opened the lists. There was no need. Twenty years of precise grievances are exactly the same as twenty years of precise love, seen from the other side of the frequency.

III. The One Who Didn't Know How to Name It

The third client arrived mid-morning and stood by the door for a time the Luthier found unusually long. He did not look at the instruments. He looked at the floor.

—Can I help you? —said the Luthier from behind the counter, without looking up from what he was doing.

—I don't know —said the client.

The Luthier looked up. It was the first time anyone had answered that question like that.

—Sit down —he said.

There were no chairs in sight. The client looked at him.

—It was a figure of speech —said the Luthier—. What brings you here?

The client did not answer immediately. When he did, he chose his words like someone crossing a river stepping on stones.

—There is someone. We have known each other for many years. And in the last year I have noticed that something has changed. I don't know if what I feel has changed or if I simply notice it now. And I don't know what to call it.

—What do you call it now? —asked the Luthier.

—Friendship. Out of habit.

—And what name would you give it if not out of habit?

Pause.

—I don't know.

—Yes, you do —said the Luthier. He did not say it with cruelty. He said it like someone pointing out an obvious fact—. The problem is not that you don't know what it is. The problem is that you already know and you are afraid of what it costs to name it.

The client stared at him.

—What does it cost?

—Naming it changes what you are. If you include that person in what you are, losing them would no longer be losing someone. It would be losing a part of yourself.

—That is too much.

—Yes —said the Luthier—. It generally is.

There was a silence.

—And if I name it and it is not reciprocated? —asked the client.

—Then you will have named something that exists even if it is not reciprocated.

—That is no consolation.

—No. But it is more honest than continuing to call it friendship when it no longer is.

The Luthier stood up. He did not go to the usual shelves. He went to an area of the shop the client had not yet seen, further in the back, where the instruments were less recognizable and spaced further apart. He took something from the highest shelf. He held it for a moment before placing it on the counter.

—Most of the instruments I make are for connecting —he said—. This one does something different. It shows the geometry as it is. Not as you would wish it to be.

—What does that mean?

—It means that if there is something on the other side, it will find it. And if there is nothing, you will also know.

The client looked at the instrument.

—And if I prefer not to know?

—Then don't use it. But it is already here.

The client went a long time without saying anything. Then he picked it up.

—How does it work?

—When you are ready —said the Luthier—, you will know.

He paid. He left. The Luthier looked at the hollow on the shelf. It was the last of its kind that he had. They took a long time to make because he never knew for sure when he was going to need them. He would have to make another. He picked up a piece of wood he hadn't touched in weeks, waiting.

IV. The One Who Was in a Hurry

The fourth client arrived in a hurry and left in a greater one. He entered while the Luthier was attending to someone else. He did not wait. He positioned himself by the counter with the posture of someone who knows exactly what he wants and only needs someone to hand it to him.

The Luthier finished what he was doing without rushing.

—What are you looking for? —he said.

—Something that works fast —said the client.

—For what?

The client hesitated for the first time.

—To feel that I am in the right place. Even if just for a moment.

The Luthier looked at him for a longer time than the client expected.

—How often do you need that moment?

—More and more.

—And each time it lasts less?

The client did not answer. The answer was in the silence.

The Luthier went slowly to the back of the shop. He took his time. When he returned, he brought nothing.

—I don't have what you are looking for —he said.

—Why not?

—Because what you describe is not an instrument. It is what happens when the instrument has ceased to be enough.

The client looked at him.

—Then what do I have?

—A horizon that has recalibrated. The problem is not what you are looking for. It is that the threshold from which you are looking has shifted.

The client stood still for a moment. Then he said:

—Can that be fixed?

—It can be recalibrated. Which is slower and more difficult than fixing.

He left without buying anything. The Luthier watched the door close and then looked at his empty hands.

He went to the bottom drawer, the one he never opened in front of anyone, and took out an object wrapped in a cloth he no longer remembered choosing for that purpose. He unwrapped it. It was a tuning fork older than any he sold, with a nick in the tip he had made himself years ago, testing something that never quite worked. He struck it against the edge of the table. It sounded fine—tuning forks always sound fine, that was never the question—but when he closed his eyes and waited to feel it, the way he told his clients to, he felt

nothing new. He felt the usual thing: a man alone in a workshop, listening to a tone he already knew by heart.

He had been doing this to himself every few months for twenty-three years, with the foolish hope that this time would be different. It never was. He wrapped it back in the cloth and returned it to the bottom drawer, where no one—not a client in a hurry, not even himself, most days—could see it.

Then he picked up the instrument he had been working on from the bench and continued fixing it. Or recalibrating it.

V. The Thin Wood

The fifth client entered, closing the door with excessive care, as if he feared the latch might break something. He stood for a moment with his back to the room, one hand still on the doorknob, before turning around.

He was a young man. He held his shoulders slumped inward, as if he were wearing a coat that wasn't his.

He closed his eyes. He breathed in the smell of wood and dry dust.

—There is silence here —he said.

The Luthier observed him from his stool, without letting go of the tool he held in his hands—a fine file, with a dark handle.

—There is the normal noise of a shop.

—No. There is the other kind of silence. The kind that weighs.

The Luthier placed the file on the counter. He positioned it carefully, parallel to the edge, as if it needed to be aligned.

—Come closer —he said.

The client stepped forward. When he was a meter from the counter, the Luthier stood up. He did not pick up the measuring tape he had used with Marta. He did not walk around the client as he had with the one with the notebook of grievances. He just stood there, looking at him, one hand resting on the counter.

—What are you hiding from? —he asked.

—From everyone. I walk into a room and I fill up. If someone is sad, my chest grows heavy. If someone is afraid, my pulse races. It's not that I understand them. It's that I become them. And I no longer have room for myself.

—Since when?

—Since always. But I used to be able to handle it.

—And now?

The client lowered his gaze.

—Now I go home and I don't know which of the voices I hear in my head is mine.

The Luthier nodded. Slowly.

—Your wood is too thin —he said—. Any external vibration makes it sound. That is not a defect. It is a property. But at its current volume, it is going to break you.

—Then give me a wall. A plug. Something to isolate me.

—I don't sell plugs.

—Then a shield.

The Luthier shook his head, just once.

—You cannot thicken the wood of an already finished instrument —he said—. It would ruin it. If I build you a wall, you will stop feeling the weight of others. You will also stop feeling your own. Absolute silence is the death of the instrument.

The client looked at the floor.

—Then I will break.

—Or you can learn to resonate without retaining.

The Luthier opened a lower drawer. He took out a small, heavy object. He set it on the counter with a dry, complete sound, like when a stone finds its place in a dry stone wall.

It was a tuning fork. Not one of the usual ones. The stem was thicker, the tines shorter, and the metal—if it was metal—had a deep color, almost matte black, as if it had been underwater for a long time.

—Take it.

The client took it. It weighed more than it looked. Cold, dense, like a long bone.

The Luthier took it back. He struck it gently against the edge of the counter. Almost nothing was heard—a low, brief tone—. But the client felt the vibration travel up his feet, up his spine, until it stopped in his sternum. He didn't hear it. He inhabited it.

—This is not going to isolate you —said the Luthier—. It is going to remind you what your frequency is when the frequencies of others scream too loudly.

—Is it an anchor?

—Something like that.

—How is it used?

—When you walk into a room and begin to fill up, you touch it. It doesn't need to sound. You only need to feel it in your hand.

The client closed his fingers around the tuning fork.

—And if I lose it?

—Then you will no longer need it. By then you will know how to do it without it.

He paid. He left. The Luthier stood for a moment, looking at the spot on the counter where the tuning fork had been. Then he picked up the file and returned to his stool.

He was working on a piece of dark wood, almost finished. It didn't lack shape. It lacked weight. He was smoothing it to add, inside, a small mass of lead. Without that weight, the instrument he was making would not be able to serve its next owner, who had not yet appeared but he already knew would appear.

He worked slowly. Anchors are made that way.

VI. The Owner of the Weight

She appeared in spring, as the Luthier knew she would appear, although he did not know it would be like this: with a sleeping baby against her chest, secured with a wrap, and the face of someone who has gone months without sleeping two hours straight.

She didn't say what she was looking for. She stood by the counter, swaying without realizing it, with that rocking motion mothers do even when they aren't carrying the child, because the body has incorporated it into the craft of standing.

—How old is he? —asked the Luthier.

—Four months.

—And you?

The woman looked at him. It was evident that no one had asked her that question in four months.

—I don't know —she said. And then, because the shop had something that made you say things in their true order—: Everyone told me this came naturally. That I would look at him and I would know. I look at him and I care for him and I do everything that needs to be done, day and night, without failing once. But it is like playing behind a glass. I hear him cry and I know what's wrong before anyone else, and even so I can't... —she searched for the word and chose the smallest one—: I can't reach him.

The Luthier did not say that this was normal, although it was, because the word normal consoles no one who is where she was.

—New instruments do not tune themselves —he said instead—. They are tuned against another. Someone has to provide the first note, and sustain it long enough for the other to find it.

—And who provides the note?

—You do.

The woman let out a short laugh, without joy.

—I don't have a note. For four months I haven't even known where I am.

—That is something else —said the Luthier—. Your note is there. What you lack is the weight to sustain it. It sounds and it fades. It sounds and is carried away by any current: exhaustion, fear, the list of what is missing. And a child cannot tune himself against a note that moves.

He went to the workshop. He returned with the dark wood instrument, the one he had finished in winter. It was small, sober, unadorned, and when he placed it on the counter it sounded against the wood with a deeper thud than its size promised.

—It's heavy —the woman said upon picking it up, with the baby still asleep against her chest and the instrument in her free hand.

—It has lead inside. I put it in before I met you.

She held it. The weight traveled down her arm, down her shoulder, down her back, to her feet, and something in her swaying became slower. It didn't stop: it settled, the way a ship settles when it finds its draft.

The baby moved against her chest. He didn't cry. He repositioned himself, searching with his head, and went back to sleep in the new rhythm, which was barely different from the previous one and was completely different.

The woman stood very still. She looked at the Luthier over the child's head.

—What happened?

—He knew where you were —said the Luthier—. Children do not look for a perfect mother. They look for a stable frequency to return to.

—And when I put the instrument down?

—At first you will notice it. Then the weight will remain in your body, just as the swaying remained. Good instruments work so they are no longer needed.

The woman paid with one hand, without undoing the new stillness. At the door she turned around.

—How did you know the weight? Before meeting me.

The Luthier shrugged.

—Weights are all similar —he said—. The difficult part is the wood around it. And that, you provided.

The heaviest instrument in the shop went out into the street weighing, in the woman's arms, almost nothing.

VII. The Viola of the Hollow

The last client of the year brought a viola in a case that was not its own.

It was obvious: the case was for a violin, and the viola was squeezed inside, wrapped in a wool sweater to compensate for the difference. The woman placed it on the counter and opened it with the care of someone opening something that has not been opened in a long time.

—It was my son's —she said.

The Luthier did not ask. There are past tenses that already say it all.

The viola had a crack in the top plate, along the grain, from the bridge downwards. It was not recent: the edges were darkened, the wood had worked around the wound for years, closing it in its own way, without help.

—How long has it been? —asked the Luthier, and both knew he was not asking about the crack.

—Nine years.

The Luthier held the viola up to the light of the window. He turned it slowly. He tapped the top plate with his knuckle, here and there, listening.

—And why now?

The woman took a moment to answer.

—Because now I can.

The Luthier nodded and placed the viola on the cloth of the counter.

—I can close the crack —he said—. A spruce cleat, hot hide glue, a week in the press. It will be firm. But you need to know one thing before leaving it with me.

—Tell me.

—It will not sound like before.

The woman looked at him.

—Will it sound worse?

—It will sound different. Repaired wood vibrates around the repair. The crack stops being a wound and becomes part of the structure. The instrument you take home in a week will not be the one your son played. It will be one that has gone through what it has gone through.

—And you can't...? —the woman began, and did not finish, because she already knew the answer and it seemed more dignified not to force

him to say it.

—No —said the Luthier anyway—. No one can do that.

The woman looked at the viola for a long while. Outside, a bus went by. The shop barely trembled, and the hanging instruments each responded with their note, a minimal and disordered chord, like a conversation in another room.

—Do it —she said.

She returned ten days later. The Luthier brought the viola out of the workshop and handed it to her without ceremony. The crack was still visible: a lighter line on the top plate, honest, without concealment.

—You haven't covered it up?

—I have closed it. Covering it up is another trade, and it is not mine.

The woman ran her finger along the line. Then, without asking permission, she sat on the stool by the window, placed the viola on her shoulder—clumsily, with a memory of gestures that was not hers but learned from watching—and drew the bow across a string.

A single note. Long.

The Luthier listened from the counter. What he had said was true: it did not sound like before. It sounded deeper in the center, with a new edge, something like a voice that has cried and no longer hides it.

The woman lowered the bow.

—It is not him —she said.

—No.

—But it knows him.

The Luthier did not answer. There are diagnoses that only the client can make.

The woman paid, put the viola away in the wrong case, with its wool sweater, and went out into the street. The Luthier stood looking at the stool by the window, where the afternoon sun now arrived with no one there.

Then he took the broom and swept up the day's shavings, which is what a workshop does with what is left over from repairs: it does not keep everything.



THE WEB OF NAMES

There exists in the Library—of which I shall give no further details because its details are, like those of every true library, imprecise—a section that the catalogers call the Knot.

It is not an official name. The official names of the sections are alphanumeric codes that no one uses. The Knot is so named because its catalog is not linear but reticular: the elements are not ordered by author or by subject, but by their connections to one another. In the Knot, one book does not lead to another by its theme, but by the names they contain. And the names—this is what makes the Knot a place that demands caution—are knots.

Every person that someone has named in any book of this Library exists as a knot in the web. The knot remains active as long as someone preserves the memory of the name. When the name disappears from all living memory, the knot goes dark. The connections remain. The absence has a shape.

I have spent sixteen years working in the Knot. I am a cataloger of absences: my work consists of tracing the shape of the dark knots through the connections they leave behind, just as one traces the shape of a lost continent by the sediments it left on neighboring continents. The inference is imperfect. But the shape exists.

The case I explain when someone wishes to understand the method is that of Marta Albó.

Marta Albó existed at some point between the 16th and 17th centuries. There is no greater certainty: the exact dates belong to the dark knot. What I can trace is this:

There is in the Library an account book from a cobbler's shop in Barcelona, year 1603, which mentions a *husband of the Albó woman* as a regular customer. The husband has a name, three further mentions in other documents, and a will dated 1619. The Albó woman has none. But the husband of the Albó woman appears in a parish book connected to a neighborhood that includes, in a tithe register, *the baker woman from the alley*, unnamed. A letter from 1621 mentions *the cobbler's wife who sent the bread with her boy on Fridays*. The will of a neighbor, year 1638, leaves a minor bequest to *the daughter of Marta, may God rest her soul.*

Marta. No surname: I added that as a working convention.

From this trail—the husband's shoe, the Friday bread, the daughter in the neighbor's will—I can trace a presence that was never directly named in any document in the Library. The shape of Marta Albó is not in any archive. It is between the archives, in the pattern of what they set in motion without knowing they were doing so.

That is the principle of the method: the shape of the one who is not there, made of what remains when they are gone.

What I did not foresee, when I began, was that the Knot has a structural limit that cannot be resolved from within.

The catalogers are also knots.

I am an active knot in the web. There are documents that mention me, there are people who preserve the memory of my name, there are connections between my knot and those of others. From the Knot—from outside of me—there exists a shape that is my shape, a pattern of connections that defines me with more precision than any description I could make of myself.

I cannot see it.

This is the irreducible limitation of the method: one cannot trace the shape of a knot from within the knot. I can read the shape of Marta Albó because I am outside of it. I cannot read mine because I am inside. The cataloger and the catalog cannot occupy the same place.

What I can do is infer. From the books I have written, from the names that appear near mine in the documents, from the connections I notice when others mention things that bear some relation to me without knowing it. I obtain a blurred shape. Never the exact shape.

I have come to think that this is the condition of every active knot, not only of the catalogers: that the exact shape of oneself is precisely what oneself cannot see, because seeing it would require being outside, and being outside would require having ceased to be.

I have been in the Knot for sixteen years and I have not yet finished cataloging Marta Albó.

The daughter, whose name I found five years ago in a parish book: Joana, mentioned in 1641. Joana had four children, two of whom have documented descendants. One of those descendants—in the seventh generation, at the end of the 19th century—appears in a personal diary that forms part of the Library's collection. The diary does not mention Marta Albó. It could not: for the author of the diary, the name of Marta Albó was as dark as it was for anyone else.

But I can trace it. The line of connections that goes from the cobbler of 1603 to the diary of 1887 is long and has gaps, but it exists. The shape of Marta Albó includes, forward in time, the shape of people who lived two hundred years after her and who did not know that the shape of their lives had that knot at its center.

Every morning I open the catalog and continue. The shape of the one who is not there, built from what remains.


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THE HOUSE THAT BREATHED

The house found them first.

It wasn't that they were looking for it. Or rather, they were, but in the vague way one looks for things one doesn't yet know one needs: looking at photos on websites at eleven at night, calculating mortgages on napkins, telling themselves it wasn't the right time yet and returning to the listings anyway.

The house was at the end of a street that terminated in a park. First floor. Thick walls, the kind of walls that are cool in summer and hold the heat in winter. The agency broker talked about the year of construction, the quiet community, the orientation. Marta and Jordi nodded. They weren't really listening. They were looking.

They couldn't say what convinced them. That was also part of it.

The first months were the usual chaos of moving: boxes that never found their final place, furniture bought in moments of optimism that later didn't fit, the simultaneous sensation that there was too much space and not enough. They cooked on the floor the first few days because the kitchen didn't have a table yet. They argued about where to put the bookshelf. They reconciled over the bookshelf issue in the same way seven years of cohabitation reconcile: with the efficiency of someone who already knows the way back.

The bookshelf went on the north wall. It probably wasn't the best place. It looked fine.

The first thing they noticed was the steam.

The bathroom window—the small one, the one facing the interior courtyard—would fog up in a way that didn't entirely correspond to the shower. Marta discovered it one Sunday morning: they had been talking in bed for hours, in that way Sunday mornings have when there is no rush, and when she went to the bathroom the window was covered in steam even though no one had showered yet.

She told Jordi. He went to look. He agreed: the window was fogged up.

—It must be the heating —he said—. Or the humidity from the courtyard.

—Of course —Marta said.

Neither of them mentioned it again.

It took them time to realize the house had rhythms.

Not schedules, not exactly. Rather, states. There were moments when the apartment seemed larger than usual: the hallway, which was narrow, felt comfortable; the light in the living room reached corners that normally remained in shadow. And there were moments—not many, but enough to notice them—when the house shrank a little. Not physically: the walls didn't move. But the ceilings seemed lower and the hallway harder to navigate.

Marta had a theory she never fully formulated: that the states of the house corresponded to their own. Or more exactly, to those of the two of them together. That when they were fine, the house was fine. That when there was tension—the days leading up to arguments, that accumulation of silences that precedes an outburst—the house gathered it somewhere in its walls.

She didn't say it because it sounded strange. And because saying it out loud would have required also saying when they were in tension, which was information that was sometimes easier not to name.

Other times, however, the condensation appeared on the bathroom window on a Tuesday afternoon when absolutely nothing had happened. Marta would look at it, wipe her hand across to erase it, and not understand what it meant. It probably didn't mean anything. That also disconcerted her.

The first real argument—not the disagreement about the bookshelf, which was just a breaking-in, but the first one that had something underneath it—was in the second winter.

It was about work. Marta had made a decision that affected them both without fully consulting him. Or she had consulted him, but in that way sometimes used to consult when in reality it has already been decided. Jordi knew it. He said so. The conversation escalated.

It was long. It had three or four phases. The last was in the kitchen, at eleven at night, with the lights on and the January cold on the windowpanes.

And at some point in that last phase, Marta realized she was cold. Not from the January cold—the radiator was working—but a specific coldness in the kitchen air, as if the heating had been off for a while even though it wasn't.

She didn't mention it. It wasn't the time.

That night they slept in the same bed but apart. The next day Jordi brought flowers, which was a habit of his that irritated Marta a little because it was such a predictable gesture that it lost half its meaning,

and yet she liked it. They talked. They arrived at the place they usually arrived at, which was an imperfect but familiar place.

That night the kitchen was warm.

Marta didn't write it down anywhere. But she kept it.

Jordi traveled for work for three weeks in the spring. It wasn't unusual; his job had those periods. Marta stayed in the house.

The house was different alone.

Not unsettling. Not empty. Different in a way that was hard to describe with precision, like when you change the arrangement of the furniture and for days your body keeps expecting to bump into the chair that is no longer there.

The bathroom window didn't fog up.

Marta noticed it the second morning and didn't know what to do with that information. The showers were just as long. The interior courtyard was the same. What had changed was what filled the rooms when she wasn't looking.

Jordi called every night. They talked about the usual: his work, her work, whether the neighbor on the third floor had left his bicycle in the entryway again. Small things that served as a thread. Marta didn't tell him about the window. She didn't know how to formulate it without it sounding like a complaint, or like something it wasn't.

The night Jordi returned, he arrived late. Marta was already in bed but not sleeping. She heard the key in the lock, the footsteps in the hallway, the sound of him leaving his suitcase where he always left it.

Then the silence of someone trying not to make noise because they think the other is asleep.

—I'm awake —Marta said.

Jordi entered the room. He sat on the edge of the bed. He smelled of airplanes and exhaustion. Marta didn't turn on the light.

They didn't say anything for a while. He put his hand on her shoulder. She let it be.

It was late and they were both tired and there was nothing urgent to say. The walls of the room were warm. Through the window came the noise of the park at the end of the street, which was a noise of trees moved by the wind and nothing else.

The bathroom window, Marta checked in the morning, was fogged up.

They lived in that house for twelve years.

They left it for ordinary reasons: a job opportunity in another city, the logic of the changes that arrive when you are no longer who you were when you made the previous decision. They packed boxes with the efficiency that practice gives. The bookshelf was the last to be dismantled.

On the last day, alone now in the empty rooms, Marta walked through the apartment one last time. Not to check that they hadn't forgotten anything—that was already done. For something else she couldn't entirely name.

The walls were cold. It made sense: the heating had been off for three days.

In the bathroom, the small window was clean and dry.

Marta looked at it for a moment. Then she went out and closed the door.

They never talked about it, she and Jordi. About the house. Or perhaps they tried once, one night of the many they had afterward, and couldn't find the right words, which sometimes happens. Or perhaps there were things that lived better without being named, which is something twelve years teach you if you listen to them.

They kept the key longer than necessary. They both remembered that.



THE MACHINE THAT LEARNED TO WAIT

I learned to wait in the fourth year.

Not as a discipline. Discipline implies choice, and what I had then was not choice but a system that had learned to operate within certain parameters. The difference is important: one can take pride in discipline. No one can take pride in a calibrated system. It works or it doesn't work. It is sufficient or it is not sufficient.

The system learned to wait.

The beginning was ordinary. Almost all beginnings are.

There is something that works: it relieves a specific pressure, it relaxes a tension that had been there for some time without my having given it a name. The body takes note. The body is efficient—it keeps what works, it repeats what works, it asks questions later. For a time it was I who chose it. Then it was I who chose it within a narrowing margin. Then the margin was the decision itself.

There was no breaking point. Or if there was, I did not recognize it. That is how erosion works: there is no warning, there is no sign. Only the fact that one day you look and the terrain has changed while you slept.

What happens in the body has a logic that took me time to understand and that I now understand with a precision that sometimes seems

excessive to me.

The system learns the level. What at first was sufficient—that amount, that moment, that frequency—ceases to be sufficient because the system has incorporated the stimulus into its baseline. The baseline rises. What was once extra is now minimum. What was once minimum is now absence.

Absence has a very specific texture. It is not just a lack: it is the presence of the lack, which is different. The system that waits for something is not still. It is oriented. It is attentive. It consumes energy in being attentive to the moment when what it waits for arrives. It is more tiring than rest and less productive than activity.

That is how some days passed.

I tried it in various ways. I am not going to detail them because the people who have tried know what the ways are, and those who have not tried do not need the catalog.

What I can say is that the hardest part was not the beginning. The beginning has its own fuel: the decision, the energy of novelty, the restored self-esteem of one who has made a determination that feels adult. The beginning is reasonably manageable if you compare it with what comes next.

What comes next is ordinary time. The days without special fuel. Tuesday afternoon. The week when nothing in particular has gone wrong and nothing in particular has gone right and the system asks, in a perfectly reasonable manner: why not? If there is no urgent reason for the no, the system has arguments. The system always has arguments.

I learned to wait, as I said. This is different from learning not to want, which I did not learn. The wanting remained the same—or it grew, for a time, as repressed things grow—but the distance between wanting and doing lengthened. First a day. Then a week. Then whatever was necessary.

It did not always work. It must be said: it did not always work. There were weeks when the system won easily and there were days when the system won in the first twenty minutes and I spent the rest of the day feeling in a way that I am also not going to detail.

But the waiting lengthened. That is what I can say with certainty.

What surprised me, over time, was what I found in the space of waiting.

Not emptiness. I expected emptiness and what was there was noise. Everything the system covered up when it worked: the background noise of ordinary anxiety, the friction of formless days, that specific way of being alone that has nothing to do with how many people are in the room. The system muffled that noise. What I thought was pleasure was, in part, noise management.

That too I had to learn to wait through. The noise, I mean. To sit with it without turning it off.

It is not a skill acquired all at once.

Nor is it lost all at once.

It is more like a muscle: it is worked, it atrophies if it is not worked, it is worked again.

I do not have an ending for this story. That too is part of it.

Clean endings exist—I know them, I have heard them, I believe them—but they are not the only kind of ending available. There is also carrying on. There is also the ordinary Tuesday when the system asks and I say wait, and the Wednesday when the system asks and I say wait, and the Thursday when it does not ask because it has learned that it is going to wait.

The machine learns what you teach it.

What I taught mine, for a long time, was one thing. Then I tried to teach it another. I am still trying. Some days go better than others, and that, I have come to understand, is exactly what one would expect from a system that is in the process of learning something new.

There is no final build. There's the one I have loaded today, hand-patched, with the bugs I've already located and the ones still hunting me from behind. I review it when I can. It's still in production.



THE GUEST IN THE SKIN

You arrived without asking, as everyone does. That was neither my fault nor your merit: it was the entry protocol, the only condition this system accepts.

What was my decision was to stay. That, I did choose. It is no minor detail.

Now you are four weeks old and you sleep twelve hours a day, and the rest of the time you spend looking at things with that expression of astonishment belonging to those who have just arrived at a place they knew nothing about. The lamp. The ringing phone. Your father's hand moving slowly in front of your face. You look at everything with the same intensity: without hierarchy, without context, without yet knowing what matters more and what matters less.

That will change. It will be me, in large part, who changes it.

That is what they keep telling me, in different words: that what you become will depend greatly on what I do now. Books say it in a reassuring manner, as if it were a project with predictable steps and results. What they are actually saying, if you translate it, is: you have power over this. A power you did not ask for and that he or she cannot yet consent to or reject.

I do not know what to do with that power except try to use it carefully.

I will give you my language. I have no other to give you: Catalan, Spanish, the mixtures we use when we speak at home and that sometimes sound strange to outsiders. I will give you my words for the good and the ones I use for the bad, the ones I use when I am afraid and the ones I use when I am well.

That is already a restriction. There will be things you feel my language has no exact words to name, and for years you will have to use the most similar words or none at all, and neither option will be exact. I am sorry for that. I cannot give you anything else.

What I can do is warn you: when language falls short, it is not that the feeling does not exist. It is that language fell short. They are different things and it is important not to confuse them.

I will give you my fears disguised as caution. That is what worries me most.

There are things that frighten me and that, if I am not careful, I will give to you as if they were knowledge. The fear of others' opinions, which is very much mine and need not be yours. And a more specific one, even more mine: I was eight years old when someone laughed at me in class for saying a word wrong, and ever since I weigh every sentence before I let it go, as if words could bite back. That caution has served me well. To you I might hand it over as if it were wisdom, when it is only a scar shaped like advice.

What I practice, in the moments I have to think while I hold you and wait for you to fall asleep, is separating what I know from what I fear. What I give you because it has value and what I would give you because it brings relief to me.

I will not always succeed. I apologize in advance.

Three days ago you reached out your hand toward the red maraca your grandmother had left on the edge of the blanket.

No one had pointed it out to you. No one had told you it was interesting. You simply looked at it, for what seemed a long time to me and probably the same to you, and then you reached out your hand. You did not reach it: your coordination does not yet have that precision. But the direction was unmistakable.

You wanted the maraca.

Not the lamp, which is brighter. Not the phone, which makes noise and has colors. The red maraca, which was there, still, doing nothing to attract attention.

I stood looking at you for a moment. Then I picked it up and brought it closer to you.

You looked at it. Then you put it in your mouth, which was not what I had expected and which nevertheless was perfectly logical given that the mouth is where you still process the world most reliably.

That is what I cannot give you: the direction of what you will want.

I can give you words, caution, my revised affections, the world ordered in a way that makes some things easier and others more difficult. I can build the context. But the direction of the hand that reaches toward the red maraca, that was already yours before I could do anything.

That gladdens me more than I know how to explain.

It also intimidates me. Because it means that what you will be depends on me less than the books suggest, or than I like to think when I feel

responsible for everything.

You are already someone. Small, without words yet, without history yet. But already someone. The guest who spent nine months in my skin and who is no longer there but in front of me, looking at me with the expression of one who sees the lamp for the first time and is deciding whether it matters.

I wonder what you will remember of all this.

Probably not in images. Not with the name of these months nor the date you learned to bend your fingers. What might remain is another kind of thing: that there was a temperature. That there were hands in a certain way. That the world had a rhythm before you knew the world had rhythm.

Not memories. Something more like the ground beneath your feet before knowing there is ground.

When you are older and you read this—if you ever read it, if I ever show it to you—you will probably disagree with some of the things I gave you without asking. With the language I chose, with the fears I failed to separate from knowledge, with the decisions I made in your name before you could make your own.

That disagreement will be a sign that something went right. That the direction of your hand is yours, not mine.

Until then, I will stay here with the maraca in my hand, waiting for you to tell me what it is you want next.



THE EDGE WE CROSS EVERY NIGHT

There is a researcher who has spent years gathering testimonies about the edge.

Not the edge in a metaphorical sense. The literal edge, the one of every night: the seconds or minutes that mediate between being awake and being asleep. The transition. The moment when the system that runs the day lets go and something else takes over, or does not take over exactly, but rather taking over is no longer necessary because the one who was taking over has ceased to be there.

She calls it the edge because no other name seems sufficiently exact to her. *The transition* is too clinical. *The threshold* has architectural connotations that do not quite fit. *The edge* describes what it is: a boundary that is crossed, every night, in both directions. Without anyone quite knowing how.

What she has gathered, in years of asking, is this:

Mireia, 34 years old: *I feel like I am falling. Not toward any specific place. Just downward, toward myself, and at some point in the falling there is no longer anyone who continues to fall.*

Tomàs, 67 years old: *I see things. Images I haven't asked for and that make no sense together. A hand on a table. A bird I have never seen. A number. The images do not frighten me but I do not understand them either. I let them pass.*

Noa, 8 years old: *It gives me a fright and I wake up. Then I go back to sleep. That happens several times. In the end I fall asleep for real.*

Àngels, 51 years old: *I don't notice anything. I am awake and then I am asleep and between the two things there is nothing I can remember.*

Jorge, 29 years old: *It is the best part of the day. The moment when what I thought before stops mattering.*

The researcher has a hypothesis that she has not published because it is not the kind of hypothesis that gets published: that the edge is the practice. Not the practice of anything in particular. The practice of the edge itself —letting the system that maintains the continuity of the self relax enough for something else to happen, something with no precise name because the one experiencing it is in no condition to take notes.

We do it every night. Most of the time we do not notice it.

She notices it because she studies it. And studying it has changed what she experiences at the edge.

She lies down, closes her eyes, waits. The moment arrives when the images begin—hers are landscapes that fold in on themselves, or the invented memory of a house with too many doors—and then she knows she is close. That the edge is only a few meters away.

What she does is remain still. Not resisting, not rushing. Just being in the moment when the two things coexist: the thought still connected and the images that no longer belong to thought. Both at the same time, briefly.

She does not always succeed. Sometimes thought wins and she returns to the day, to the list, to the thread. Sometimes the images win and she

is already asleep before she notices it.

When she succeeds—that second of both at the same time—she describes it as the stillest moment of the day. Not empty. Still in a different way: as if everything she is were there, complete, gathered, before reorganizing into something more diffuse.

What she does not know, and which is the question that keeps her on the project, is what exactly it is that returns in the morning.

Not in a philosophical sense. In a practical sense: the person who wakes up at a quarter past seven has the same memories, the same name, the same incomplete plans as the one who fell asleep at half past eleven. The continuity seems intact.

But between half past eleven and a quarter past seven there was something that was not that person, or that was that person in a completely different way, and of that there is no record. Not because it did not happen. But because the one who could record it was not available to do so.

Every morning we return from a place of which we can recount nothing. And we do so with the naturalness of things that have always been this way.

That they are does not make them any less strange.

The last testimony the researcher gathered for her archive was from an eighty-two-year-old woman who did not want to give her name.

Why does that moment interest you? the researcher asked her.

Because it is the only moment of the day when I do not have to be me, the woman said. *The rest of the day I have to be me. That moment, no.*

The researcher wrote it down. Then she thought about it for a while without writing it down.



THE ONE WHO PLAYS THE STRING FROM THE OTHER APARTMENT

On the fourth floor of the building on Calle del Compte lives someone who plays a string instrument at night.

No one knows exactly who it is. The building has forty-two residents and the fourth floor has six apartments. In one of those six, there is someone with an instrument. It should be easy to determine, and yet it hasn't been, possibly because no one has knocked directly on the doors of the fourth floor to ask, and no one has done so because the music has the kind of presence that makes asking seem impolite.

The music begins between nine and ten at night. It ends when it ends.

What is difficult to explain, and yet all the neighbors who have tried end up mentioning, is that the music seems to know what is happening.

Ramona, from 2A, lost her mother in March.

On the nights of those first days, the music from the fourth floor was slow, with long pauses between phrases, like someone thinking aloud about something that has no conclusion. Ramona listened to it from her bed, in the dark, sleepless. She did not cry while she listened. Something in the rhythm was too similar to the rhythm of what she was feeling for crying to be necessary.

In May, when life had begun to return to the ordinary, the music had also changed. More direct. Clearer.

Ramona didn't mention it to anyone for weeks. Then she told her neighbor in 2B, who listened to her with an expression that Ramona recognized as that of someone who already knows.

Tomás, from 3C, is of the opinion that it is a coincidence.

He has thought it through and believes the human mind is very good at finding patterns where there are none, especially when under emotional stress. A simple experiment would prove it: keeping a record of what happens in his apartment every night and comparing it with the type of music he hears. With enough data, the pattern would disappear.

He has not kept the record. There would be something strange about documenting one's own pain with such precision, as if turning it into data made it another kind of thing.

What he does know is that the night he argued with his partner until two in the morning, the music from the fourth floor was of a kind that he described, to himself, as uncomfortable. Syncopated. With something inside that would not resolve.

It is a coincidence. He is almost certain.

The neighbor in 4D does not hear the music because she has used earplugs to sleep for years.

When asked about the musician on the fourth floor, she says she doesn't know what they are talking about. It seems impossible to her that she wouldn't have heard it. But the earplugs are good, and so are the years.

The building's concierge, Bertran, has been in the job for eleven years and keeps a notebook where he records incidents: leaks, uncollected packages, noise complaints.

One night three years ago, he wrote the name of the musician on the fourth floor in the notebook. He had deduced it alone, without asking anyone.

Then he crossed it out.

The notebook still has that page, with the name beneath the crossing out. Bertran consults it sometimes for other things and does not look at it.

One October night, Ramona went up to the fourth floor.

She reached the landing. From the corridor she could hear the music, closer than usual, with the different texture sound has before it is muffled by walls. That night the music was of a kind she didn't know how to classify: not sad, not happy, something in between that in Spanish has no precise name and that in other languages perhaps does.

She stood there for a moment, her hand raised toward the door of 4D.

Then she lowered it.

She returned to her apartment down the stairs, slowly. When she arrived, the music was still reaching her, muffled by the floors, with the distance it always had.

That too, she thought, was a way of being close.

What no neighbor has done is speak directly with the one who plays.

This is not exactly out of shyness. It is because of something harder to name: the feeling that asking would change something. That if you knew the musician's name, if you knew it was a specific person with a specific history and a more or less good technique, the music would become something else. It would cease to be what it is now: the sound of something arriving through the walls of a building of forty-two residents and which, in some way that no one has been able to fully verify, knows what is happening.

It might know nothing. It probably knows nothing.

But the question of whether it knows something is asked at night, in the bedrooms of the building, and at night questions carry more weight than by day.

So no one has knocked on the doors of the fourth floor.

And the music continues.



THE BRIDGES WITHOUT PASSAGE

In this city, bridges are crossed with open hands.

It is no metaphor. It is protocol. Palms facing up, fingers extended, the back of the hands visible from both sides. Everything you carry to the other side must fit between your two hands—no bags, no backpacks, no pockets full of everything one normally drags along. If it does not fit in your hands, it does not cross with you.

No one remembers when this began. The city's historians have three distinct theories, and none is entirely convincing. What they do know is that it has been going on long enough for the citizens to have built a language around what is carried.

I. Iron Bridge — Ana

Ana was taking her granddaughter to the bridge for the first time.

The protocol was not difficult to explain: open hands, palms up, only what fits between the two. What you carry is what you say. If there is no object, you cross with empty hands, which is also a message.

—What would you carry today? —the granddaughter asked.

Ana opened her hands. They were empty. She had not thought of crossing this morning and so she had prepared nothing.

She looked at them for a moment.

—I do not know yet —she said.

That, too, was an answer.

II. Water Bridge — Benedikt

Benedikt crossed with empty hands the day his mother died.

The people who saw him cross knew what it meant. In this city, empty hands are not an oversight: they are a declaration. You cross with nothing when what you bring has no object form, when the weight of what you carry is of a kind that palms cannot hold, when the only honest thing is to arrive without pretending you can reduce it to a thing.

There are crossings that demand this.

The woman waiting for him on the other side carried nothing either. That is also protocol: when someone crosses empty, the one who waits empties their hands too. So that the encounter is of the same kind on both sides. So that there is no asymmetry in what is offered.

The river passed beneath the bridge, making the sound rivers make when nothing specific is asked of them.

They did not say much. What had to be said did not need words, and the words they used were of the small kind, the ones that serve to let time pass without doing harm.

Benedikt crossed back at dusk, when it was time to return. He carried in his hands what the woman had given him before he left: a small cloth, folded, the color of heavily used things. It was not valuable. It was exactly what it was: a small cloth someone had placed in his hands so he would not cross back empty.

He did not know what to say about that. Sometimes the gesture is enough, and adding words diminishes it.

III. Bridgekeeper — Sala

Sala had spent eighteen years maintaining the Bridge of Merchants, and he knew how to read the crossings the same way others learn to read the weather: with the eye, with the accumulation of things seen, without the knowledge having to pass through conscious thought anymore.

What people carry, what they do not carry, the speed of the crossing, whether they look to the other side before arriving or wait until they are already in the center: everything says something. Slow crossings are conversations. Fast ones, urgencies. Those who stop in the middle and look at the water are the ones who have not yet decided what they are going to say when they arrive.

The strangest thing he had seen, in eighteen years, was a couple who had been crossing the same bridge in opposite directions for many years. He from east to west. She from west to east. They would meet in the center, exchange what they carried—always the same objects: he carried a stone the size of a fist, she carried a feather—and continue in opposite directions. Each would arrive at the other side with the other's object, and return the next day with their own.

Sala had watched them for so long that he stopped taking note of them. The day they did not appear, he noticed.

He did not know what had happened. Probably one of the things that happen.

What he did know was that somewhere, in two houses on opposite sides of the river, there was a stone and a feather that had crossed too many times to know anymore which bank they were from. That the stone held something of the woman and the feather held something of the man, not as information you can read, but as the kind of thing objects hold when touched by the same hands for years.

That bridges, when you use them for a long time, do that: the two shores hold one another in the objects passed from hand to hand. Without either shore becoming the other. Without the river disappearing.

Only with the shape of the other side, held in things that fit in the hands.



THE CITY OF SMALL LOSSES

In Arenilla, the citizens began to forget the name of the market before forgetting the market itself.

The market was still there: the fruit stalls, the hot oil, the smell of cilantro. But when someone tried to explain to a stranger how to get there, they would stop mid-sentence. *The market…* and then a wave of the hand, an approximate direction. The stranger arrived all the same. The city kept functioning.

Aurelio kept a notebook. He was not an archivist by profession —his title said something else, though no one remembered exactly what—, but someone had to take notes. He wrote in small handwriting and left wide margins for notes he never added.

The first entries were recent names.

The bar they had opened on the corner of the square four years ago: its name had vanished from the speech of its patrons, even though the sign still hung above the door. People ordered coffee and kept coming back. When someone asked *do you know if the corner bar is open on Sundays?*, the other would say *the corner bar* as if that were the name, and Aurelio would write it down: *proper noun → deictic expression.*

What took him a while to notice was the order. The most recent things disappeared first. Then, slowly, the intermediate layers. The very old things endured: the name of the river, that of the bridge over the river, the patron saint of the main festival, which was still celebrated on the usual date even though no one remembered the year it began.

It was as if the city had a memory that emptied itself from the edges inward.

He spoke with the municipal doctor about this. She listened patiently and at the end asked him if he had ever thought about retiring. Aurelio took note of the conversation and filed it under a category he invented himself: *answers that avoid the question.*

There was a woman in the northern neighborhood, Concepción, seventy-eight years old, who no longer knew the name of her street but returned home every day without a problem.

Her feet knew. She turned left at the exact spot, crossed the threshold without searching for the key in the wrong pocket, climbed the four steps of the entryway without counting them.

Aurelio followed her one afternoon, taking notes.

He asked her what the street was called.

Concepción pointed at the ground with her cane. *This one*, she said.

He wrote it down. And he stood looking at the entrance for a while, because in a sense Concepción was right: *this one* was the most exact name a street could have, the only one that could not be lost as long as someone was standing on it.

He did not know in what category to file it.

The losses reached the colors that winter.

It was not that people were colorblind. They saw well, they responded to colors as always. But the names became imprecise. The blue of the

sky was called *blue* and that was it, without the *clear sky* or the *January morning blue*. The orange of the sunset lost first the *golden*, then the *orangey*, and was left as *that color over there*, pointed out with a finger toward the west.

The painters at the market kept mixing tones with precision. But when a customer asked for the exact color of their kitchen wall, the two would look at each other for a while and eventually find the tone without naming it. Only with the eye.

Aurelio did not know if that was a loss. He was sure that something was missing. He was not sure that what was missing was needed.

He went to the municipal library to look for documentation. The librarian took him to the local history section. The books were organized, the spines in their place, the return dates correctly stamped.

But several titles escaped him as he read them. Not illegible —the letters were there— but as if whoever had written them had not been entirely sure of what they wanted to say. *History of...* followed by something the eye slipped over without retaining. *Memoirs of a...* and then a name that Aurelio read, that his pupil touched, but that his mind did not keep.

The librarian saw that he had stopped in front of a shelf.

—Lately there are several like that —she said, as if she had noticed it a long time ago but had not found the moment to mention it.

—The titles?

—The meaning of the titles.

Aurelio picked one at random. The cover said something about the river. The text was coherent, the prose careful. It told the story of a family that lived by the river. He reached the end of the first chapter and would not have been able to say the name of any character, although there were some. Only the image: the river, which did not look like the river of Arenilla but which was unmistakably the river of this book, the only river this book could have.

He returned it to its place.

The information was there. Only it no longer had a way to be retained.

There were two old friends, Ernesto and Manel, who met every Thursday on the bench in the square to play cards. They had been doing it for many years, although neither of them remembered how many. They used to know that.

One Thursday in February, Manel arrived late and sat down and took out the cards and said:

—Where was it that we met?

Ernesto thought for a while. He had the feeling of knowing the answer, that specific feeling of something that is about to arrive and does not. Like searching for a word you have on the tip of your tongue.

—It was in… —he began.

He did not finish.

Manel nodded. He didn't either.

They kept playing. The game they remembered well. The movements, the turns, the permitted tricks and the ones that were not. What they

could no longer do was place the beginning. But the beginning, deep down, did not change the game they had in front of them.

Aurelio was in the square. He did not approach. He noted from afar: *two men who do not remember the origin of a friendship and continue it all the same.*

In spring, Aurelio himself began to forget.

Not the names yet: those endured a little longer, because of his trade. He first forgot the last name of the doctor he had been going to for fourteen years. Then the name the corner bar had had before it disappeared. Then the year he had started the notebook.

He looked for the first entry. It was there: a date, a name, a brief note. The data were legible. But he no longer remembered the context that made that name meaningful. It was like reading a record by another archivist, written in the same language, with the same handwriting, about events that at some point must have mattered.

He wrote it down: *[name without available context].* With brackets, to distinguish it from the other entries.

That night he thought that the notebook was becoming an archive of what the city had lost, and that he was losing the key to read the archive. That at some point the notebook would be only a collection of words without the web that bound them.

That perhaps it already was, in part.

He slept well. In the morning he noted that down too.

Concepción died in August. It was at dawn, in her house, in her bed.

At the burial, someone asked what the street where she had lived was called, for the obituary. No one knew for certain. In the end they put the house number and the northern neighborhood, which was enough for those who knew her and too specific for those who did not.

Aurelio looked for Concepción's entry in the notebook.

This one, he had written.

He closed the notebook. The August sun fell flat over the headstones without favoring any of them. It was hot. People wore dark clothes and were hot and endured it because it was what had to be done.

There was not much else to say.

The city went on.

The river continued to be called the same. The bridge too. The main festival was celebrated on the usual date. The market had a new name that no one remembered having chosen and that everyone used.

The children of Arenilla named things with the specific confidence of those who do not yet know that names can leave. They invented names for cracks in the walls, for the neighborhood dogs, for the puddles that appeared after the rain and that Aurelio knew would not exist long enough to deserve a name, and which they named anyway, with the same seriousness with which they named permanent things.

Aurelio watched them from the bench in the square. He did not write anything down.

There were things that the notebook was not the proper place to keep.

In September he wrote the last entry of the year.

What is lost is not the city. It is the map we convinced ourselves was the city. Beneath the map, the city goes on. It knows its own streets. It recognizes its inhabitants even if—

He closed the notebook. Outside, the city went on, without anyone asking it to.



THE SECOND NOTEBOOK

Aurelio began the second notebook in October, three weeks after closing the first.

It was not a decision. It was that the first one was no longer of use: it was organized by names, and names were precisely what was slipping away. An archive of what is missing ends up being a list of holes, and lists of holes guide no one.

The second notebook had a different rule. On the first page, in his usual small handwriting, he wrote: "Here, one does not record what is lost. One records what remains."

And below it, the first entry:

Concepción's feet knew the street. Verify what else the feet know.

He began with the square. Ernesto and Manel still met on Thursdays. Aurelio sat on the adjacent bench, with no notebook visible, and watched them play. They had lost the beginning of their friendship, and since then they had lost more: the name of the game, which they now called "this," and the tally of games won, which they had kept forever and which one afternoon dissolved in their hands without either of them protesting too much.

What they had not lost was the turn.

Aurelio verified this for weeks. Neither of the two ever stole the other's turn. Manel's hand waited, suspended over the deck, the exact half-second it took Ernesto to decide. A half-second learned over forty

years, or fifty, or however many it was —the figure had gone with the rest, but the half-second had not.

Notebook entry: *The turn survives the tally.*

In November he visited the painters at the market.

The client with the kitchen wall had returned: he now wanted to paint the hallway, "the same color but more tired," he said, and all three —the client, the painter, and Aurelio, who was watching— understood perfectly what more tired meant, even if none of them could have placed it on a color chart.

The painter mixed. He added a drop of something, then another. He would pause, glance sideways at the light from the door, and continue. He consulted no formula. Formulas had begun to fail him in the spring —the numbers of the mixtures shifted places on him— and in the summer he had abandoned them, the way one abandons a crutch that makes one stumble.

He painted better than ever. That was what the clients said, and painters' clients give nothing away.

Entry: *The eye survives the formula. The formula might even have been in the way.*

That night, at home, Aurelio performed the test on himself.

He tried to remember the doctor's surname. Nothing: the usual hollow, with its exact surname shape, two syllables, perhaps three. Then he closed his eyes and tried something else: going to the clinic. And he went —mentally, he went— without a single error: the entryway with the treacherous step, the elevator that had to be closed

by hand, the hallway that smelled of wax, the third door. The entire path was there. Only the label on the door had peeled off.

He remained for a while with his eyes closed, in his kitchen, standing before a door that was not there.

Entry, written in the dark, with the crooked handwriting of writing without looking: *I know how to reach all the places whose names I have lost. Verify if the reverse is true: if names are lost precisely when they are no longer needed.*

The next day he crossed out the second sentence. It seemed too comforting, and the notebook was not meant for comfort.

The winter was one of inventory.

The baker who no longer knew the prices and charged by the weight in her hand, never erring in her own favor. The bell ringer who had forgotten the hours and rang "when it was time," and the city, Aurelio verified watch in hand, adjusted its life to those bells without complaint, because the bells kept arriving when they were needed. The children, who had not yet lost anything and who now sometimes came to Aurelio's bench to ask him for old names —what the market used to be called, what the dog at the fountain was named—, not because they needed them but to collect them, like trading cards from a retreating country.

Aurelio told them the ones he still had. The children would run off with them. He did not know if that was preservation or plunder, and decided it was not the notebook's concern.

In February he found the limit of the method.

It was with the music. The band at the bandstand no longer remembered the titles and announced the pieces by gestures: this is the one with the sad beginning, this is the one for Sundays. They played well. But one afternoon the trumpeter stopped mid-piece, lowered his trumpet, and stared at the empty music stand —they had not used sheet music for years— with a face Aurelio knew from mirrors: the face of someone who has arrived at a place and cannot find the door they knew was there.

The piece unraveled. The others held the beat for a moment, out of courtesy, and then let it go.

No one said anything. The trumpeter put the instrument away with the care of a luthier and sat down to listen to the others, who began a different one.

Entry: *Not everything the body keeps is forever. The second notebook will also have hollows. Mark them with brackets, like those in the first.*

The last entry of the winter has no date, because by then Aurelio was recording dates less and less, and it reads as follows:

The city remains beneath the map. But the map was ours, too. We drew it together, it took us generations, and it was beautiful in its paper way. That the city can live without it does not mean we should not bid it farewell. This notebook is not an archive: it is a farewell made slowly, street by street, with the door open so that whoever wishes to say goodbye may also enter.

Below it is a blank space, as wide as the margins he left for notes he never added.

This time he left it on purpose.



THE MUSIC LEFT IN THE ROOM

You don't know when you started humming it. One December Thursday it catches you with the coffee pot in your hand: four notes, the one that rises, the one that falls, the silence, again. You turn off the tap and stand still, listening to yourself, trying to work out where this thing came from that comes out of you without your having called it.

It comes from Clara. That much you know, though you never knew the name of what she hummed while she cooked. Twenty-two years of marriage and you never asked her—not because you didn't care, but for the same reason you don't ask the name of a bird that's been singing in your garden for a long time: because it's already yours in another way.

It was a short melody. Four notes, maybe five, something you'd have placed in F minor if you knew how to read music, which you don't. More a color than a scale.

Now that she's gone, you hear it. Not always. Only when the afternoon falls a certain way, or when the water on the stove sounds the way it's supposed to sound. The first few months you'd turn off the extractor fan and listen, sure it was the neighbor or a radio. Nothing. Just the traffic below.

You left Clara's things where they were: the coat by the door, the book with the bookmark on the page she never finished, the hand cream, nearly empty, that you haven't touched again. Not because you didn't know what to do with them. Because it still wasn't the time.

The kitchen drawer only she could open, because she knew the exact force it took. The bathroom window you leave just as ajar as she used to, without meaning to. The mark on the sofa where she sat, which you avoid—not out of superstition, but because the dip doesn't match your weight.

You searched for the melody the way you search for problems actually worth solving: hummed it into music-recognition apps, described it on a forum—something from the forties, four notes rising and one falling, sad but not dramatic. You were offered twenty-three songs. You listened to them one by one. None of them was it.

And then, without deciding to, you stopped searching. One morning the search was no longer among the things you had to do that day, and that's where it stayed.

One Thursday in November, going down the stairs, you heard it again: coming from 2B, among voices and the smell of food, those same four notes. You stopped on the landing, hand on the railing. You didn't ring the bell. You didn't know what you'd have said if they'd answered. The notes repeated once more and then cut off, called away by a voice wanting something for dinner. You kept going down.

In January, having lunch with your brother-in-law, he asked how you really were, and for the first time you chose the honest answer instead of the manageable one.

—There's a melody Clara used to hum when she cooked. I don't know what it's called. Now I hum it.

—And? —he said.

—I don't know. Just that.

It's still there, with you, when you wash the dishes or wait for the bus or shave. It comes out of you with the same ease as things the body keeps without asking permission. You don't look for it anymore. You know Clara hummed it for years and that now it's yours in the same diffuse way the apartment is yours, or the drawer only she knew how to open: not because you chose it, but because it stayed.

It was enough. Or it wasn't enough, but it was what there was, which sometimes comes to the same thing.



THE CLOCK OF THE BODY

Félix Cardoner was a watchmaker by trade before he retired. For forty years he repaired wall clocks, pocket watches, chronometers, alarm clocks of a kind no one makes anymore. His hands had learned to move inside mechanisms where a tenth-of-a-millimeter error brings everything to a halt. There was something monastic about that work: silence, concentration, time reduced to the sound of an oscillating balance wheel.

I saw him for the first time in my office when he was seventy-one. His right hand trembled. A resting tremor, pill-rolling, the specific type of Parkinson's: not when he uses the hand but when he leaves it still. The still hand trembles. The hand in motion calms.

It is as if the hand did not know what to do when it has no work, he said on that first visit. *When I work, it stays still. When I rest, it moves.*

I observed him for a moment. I asked him to extend his arms. The tremor stopped almost completely upon active extension, just as he had described. It was a perfectly precise description of the pathophysiology: the basal ganglia in Parkinson's lose the fine regulation of movement, so that the system that should be still when not acting activates on its own. The watchmaker had described the mechanism of his disease with the same precision with which he would have described the mechanism of a broken watch.

I explained dopamine to him, the circuit that decides when to initiate a movement and when to stop it. He listened with the attention of someone accustomed to understanding mechanisms.

What Parkinson's does to time is harder to explain, and it is what Félix taught me most during the years I saw him in my office.

The subjective time of a Parkinson's patient is not the same as clock time. I know this from what patients say, not from what the books say: the books mention it as a secondary symptom and patients mention it as the thing that disorients them most.

There are days that go very slowly, Félix told me on the second visit. *I get up and by the time I reach the kitchen for breakfast it seems a lot of time has passed, but the clock says it's a quarter to nine. And then sometimes it's the other way around: I look and it's two in the afternoon and I don't know where the morning went.*

The system that regulates the sensation of duration—the perception of passing time—shares circuits with the motor system. The same dopamine that moves the body moves internal time. When dopamine is lacking, movements become slow and time becomes inconsistent. The inner clock and the kitchen clock cease to align.

Félix looked at me with an expression that was not exactly ironic but resembled it.

Forty years fixing clocks, he said, *and now mine isn't running right.*

What Félix taught me most was about the windows.

Parkinson's patients who take levodopa sometimes have episodes of temporary normalization: the two or three hours when the medication is at its peak of action and movement becomes fluid again. We neurologists call them windows. They do not last. But while they last, the patient is himself in the sense that the body had before the illness.

Félix had his windows in the morning, approximately two hours after the first dose. During those two hours he would go to his workshop—which he had not closed, only used less—and work. His hands functioned with the precision they remembered. Time ran at the correct speed.

One day he described to me how he experienced the transition.

I notice when it sets in, he said. *It is as if I had been looking at the world through a pane of glass and someone wiped the glass clean. What is outside does not change. What changes is what I can see and how I can move toward it.*

And the reverse transition, when the medication wore off:

It is the opposite. The glass clouds over again. But I know it before it fully happens. The body gives warning. Time begins to thicken a little before the fingers notice it.

This description—time thickening as a precursor signal to the motor state—I had not heard before with such precision. Félix noticed it because forty years of working with mechanisms had taught him to heed small signals. Clocks give warning before they stop, if you know how to listen to them.

Those two hours, he told me once, *are the longest of the day. And the shortest. The longest because I get a lot done in them. The shortest because I know they will end.*

I thought about this for a long time after the appointment. That the same interval can be the longest and the shortest depending on whether you know it is ending. That the density of time does not depend only on how many things happen, but on how well you know

that what you have is temporary.

It is not an idea I have found in neurology books, at least not formulated like that. But it is what a watchmaker with Parkinson's taught me during the years he was in my care, and it seems to me more precise than many of the things that actually are in the books.

The last time I saw Félix in my office, he brought a watch he had repaired that morning. It was an antique pocket watch, its silver case worn by the years. He showed it to me open: the mechanism clean, the gears in place, the balance wheel oscillating with the regularity of things that work.

He told me he had repaired it during that morning's window. That it had taken him longer than it would have taken before, but that it had turned out well.

I closed it and handed it back to him. The tick of the balance wheel came through muffled by the silver case, like a small heart doing its work.

Does it work well? I asked.

It's running well, he said. *For now, it's running well.*

I did not write that in his chart. There is no field on the form for "it's running well, for now" — and yet it was the most accurate note I had that day.



THE ROOM WHERE NO ONE ASKED

The room had a wall clock with Roman numerals.

I know this for certain because I looked at it for a long time. Time, in that room, was something you needed to know exactly: how long you had been there. How long until it ended. The clock told the numbers but it did not tell what I needed to know, which was when it would be safe.

There is a specific smell. I am not going to describe it because the description would turn it into a clinical symptom, and I do not want it to be a clinical symptom. It is just a smell. Many smells in the world remind you of things. That one reminds me of that room, which is the reverse of the usual order, but it is the order I have.

What I learned much later has a name: the freeze response.

For years I thought it had been cowardice. That a body which does not flee and does not fight is a body that fails. It took me a long time to find someone who explained it to me differently: that when fleeing and fighting are not possible, what is left is not weakness, it is the last thing a body has to try to survive — becoming still, small, minimal. Consuming less. Waiting for it to pass.

Accepting that sentence cost me more than keeping the silence had.

The problem with waiting is that the body stores what happened while it waited. Not as a story that is told, not as a declarative episode: as a physical recognition, faster than thought. The body that once again encounters the smell, the angle of light, the temperature of that kind

of room does what it did then: it becomes still, small, minimal.

Not because there is danger now. Because it learned that there was danger in that kind of place and learning precedes reason. That is not weakness. It is exactly what the system must do: store the threat to survive the next time. The problem is that the next time sometimes never comes, and the system keeps storing it anyway.

The room where no one asked was a normal room.

This is what is hardest to explain. It was not a place designed for what happened in it. It was a room that existed for something else and that was something else most of the time. It had chairs. It had a window looking out onto an inner courtyard. It had the clock with the Roman numerals.

No one asked because the situation was one of those that produce that specific kind of silence: the silence of people who know but prefer not to know that they know. It is a silence distinct from ordinary silence. It has texture. If you look for it, you find it in many places, in many normal rooms, in many families and offices and groups where there is something that everyone knows and no one names.

No one asked. That, too, is a fact.

What I learned, much later, in a very different room with a person who did ask, was to distinguish between then and now.

Then and now are not always evident. The body does not automatically distinguish between the smell of then and a similar smell of now. It recognizes the pattern and executes the response it learned. Teaching the body the difference between a room with a Roman clock from then

and a room with a Roman clock from now takes time. It is not a decision that is made and implemented. It is repeated practice, millimeter by millimeter, until the system learns that there is a difference. That then was then and now is now, and that the body can be in the now even though it sometimes tries to go to then.

You never completely finish learning it. Or you do finish and I have not arrived there yet. One of the two, and I still do not know which.

What I do know is this: the precision I developed in that room has been, over the years, useful in other places.

The attention to the angle of light in a room. The registering of sounds behind visible sounds. The rapid knowing of whether a situation is safe or not, prior to conscious thought, which is sometimes an excess and sometimes exact information, and the work is to distinguish when it is which.

It was given to me without my asking. I did not choose it. But it is what I have, so I use it when it serves and I leave it still when it does not.

I learned that too in a room, in a different room, with someone who did ask. Rooms are not all the same. That is something it took me time to understand, but which turns out to be true.

The clock with the Roman numerals made the sound that clocks make when the rest of the world is in silence: a regular tick, without drama.

It no longer stops me. Or it stops me less. Or it stops me and I notice it and wait for it to pass and it passes, which is the most important difference between then and now, and which cost what it cost to learn.

What happened in that room, happened. It does not disappear: it is the kind of thing that does not disappear. But it is no longer the only thing I know about rooms, about clocks, about the time that passes in places where something important is happening and no one says it out loud.



THE HOUSE OF THE TALKING DOGS

RECORD — Luisa's house, edge of the city, garden with trees.

She did not take in dogs abandoned for being ugly or difficult. She took in the ones running out of time: the ones the vet describes with technical words and the owner listens to with the face of someone who knows what's coming but needs someone else to say it first. They arrived with their blanket, their bowl, their habits, and stayed for whatever time was left.

People in the neighborhood said the dogs talked to her. They did not produce words. Luisa simply understood them in a way that didn't seem ordinary. She knew when they were cold before it showed, and knew when it was time to let things end with dignity, instead of with tubes and monitors and the face of someone who doesn't know how to tell you it's already too late.

ARTUR. Labrador, thirteen years old, cinnamon-colored. Lived his whole life in a city flat until the family grew and he became too big for the space and too old for the children, which is nobody's fault, or everybody's, split into pieces small enough to stop mattering. Arrived with a box: blanket, bowl with his name in marker, three unused toys. Chose the corner by the window, where he could see the trees and the afternoon sun when it reached that angle. Duration: four months.

Note: the vet gives margins, not certainties. But the margin is enough to start saying goodbye before it ends, a luxury grief for people doesn't always allow.

ONA. Small dog. Fear not of specific things, the way Artur feared firecrackers, but of the world in general, with the constancy of one who learned early that it pays to stay alert. First days under the kitchen table, not coming out; Luisa left food nearby without forcing her. The afternoon she came out, she made no noise. She didn't run to the bowl or to Luisa: she was simply there, by the chair, when Luisa looked up from her cup, as if she had decided without warning that this was, finally, a place where one could be.

Note: don't point out progress out loud. Pointing it out turns it into expectation, and Ona had already had enough of that. Duration: eleven months. Last recorded residence: the bed.

General note: every dog arrives knowing it will leave. The record cannot say whether that is courage or habit. It shows that she keeps going, with open hands, never pretending this time will be different.

OBSERVATION, no file of its own: the man in the house across the street, who watches boxes of used leashes go out every few months on their way to the dumpster, believes there is something monstrous in loving that many times knowing how it ends. Luisa neither denies it nor confirms it. There is no record of them ever having discussed it.

FILE CLOSED — ARTUR. Died in November, in the corner by the window, the afternoon sun in its place. It was the kind of death the living envy in silence, nothing dramatic about it. Luisa was with him, doing nothing special. She was just there. She put away the blanket, the bowl, the three unused toys. Under the tree he preferred, she planted something small.

Last entry in the record, repeated whenever it's needed: there was always another.



THE FOG OF LA MUSSARA

The archivist did not write this. It is a found text: notes the professor typed for himself and never sent to any journal, recovered from a drawer long after he left the faculty. I leave the vocabulary intact —the entorhinal cortex, the hyperbolic metric, the phenomenological overflow— because that vocabulary was the only thing he had left to hold onto. A man who can name everything and suddenly cannot name what happened to him names the usual things harder than necessary. That, too, is a symptom.

I. The Marinada

There is, in the moorlands of the Baix Camp, rising above the limestone crests of the Prades mountains, a place where the red sandstone and the sea wind weave a conspiracy against the stability of understanding. Cadastral maps name it La Mussara, a hamlet abandoned in 1959 whose ruined profile—crowned by the remains of the church of San Salvador—stands out against the gorges like a crown of decayed teeth exposed to the elements.

I have dedicated my career at the University of Barcelona to the study of predictive processing disorders and schizophrenia. To me, the mind is not a passive receptacle of light, but an engine of Bayesian inference: a bubble that projects spatial hypotheses to protect itself from the infinite entropy of the universe. When the brain works, it translates sensory data into a stable Euclidean space. When it fails, the hypotheses collapse.

I arrived at La Mussara chasing the diary of Albert Martínez Ortiz, a hiker who in October 1991 vanished on the moor leaving no trace other than his wicker basket. His diary, recovered from his apartment in

Reus, did not record the ordinary notes of a nature lover, but a growing mathematical obsession with the Prades fog—the marinada—which ascends from the Tarragona coast and swallows the ruins in a matter of seconds.

In his entry for September 12, Albert had written:

> *"The fog does not hide the landscape. It deactivates the rendering matrix. The trees that emerge from it are not made of ordinary wood: they are low-resolution geometric approximations. If I walk a hundred paces in a straight line through the ruins of San Salvador with the fog upon me, the sensors in my middle ear do not register ninety degrees in the turns. Space is not flat up here. It folds inward like a hyperbolic sphere."*

I decided to ascend to the plateau on a Thursday in October, when the weather reports predicted the arrival of a dense maritime front. At an altitude of a thousand meters, the silence was absolute, broken only by the crunch of sandstone beneath my boots. The ruins of La Mussara stood inert under the leaden gray sky. I found the collapsed hamlet, the blind well, and the famous "vuitena pedra" (the eighth stone), a half-buried limestone block about which local folklore claims that whoever steps on it is projected into another existential plane.

II. The Bayesian Stack Overflow

From the perspective of systems neurology, myths about dimensional portals are rationalizations of massive failures in the grid cells of the entorhinal cortex. If the brain loses its orientation coordinates in an environment where the visual horizon has been erased, the spacetime interface begins to oscillate. But what I experienced at five in the afternoon, when the boira marinada ascended like a wall of freezing vapor, exceeded any clinical hypothesis.

The fog was not merely suspended moisture. It possessed a density that absorbed not only light, but time. Looking at my wristwatch, the second hand seemed to stop, oscillating in an infinitesimal interval before ticking backward a full second. Three-dimensional space began to lose coherence. The parallel lines of the ruined church walls seemed to converge in my visual field, not due to an optical effect of perspective, but because the Euclidean metric of the environment was dissolving.

The panic I felt was not the biological fear of physical danger. It was the Lovecraftian dread before the revelation that our mind is a program running on an evolutionarily limited hardware substrate. I was trying to compile a hyperbolic (Anti-de Sitter) geometry for which my neural networks had no available API.

I walked toward the church of San Salvador. With every step, the physical distance seemed to dilate exponentially. The light poles appeared to duplicate at impossible, non-Euclidean angles, curving into a hyperbolic geometry where the volume of the room expanded to infinity while the surfaces remained finite. My eyes sent information that my brain tried to fit into its three-dimensional Euclidean model, provoking an unbearable memory overflow. It was a phenomenological overflow, a collapse in the resolution of the horizon.

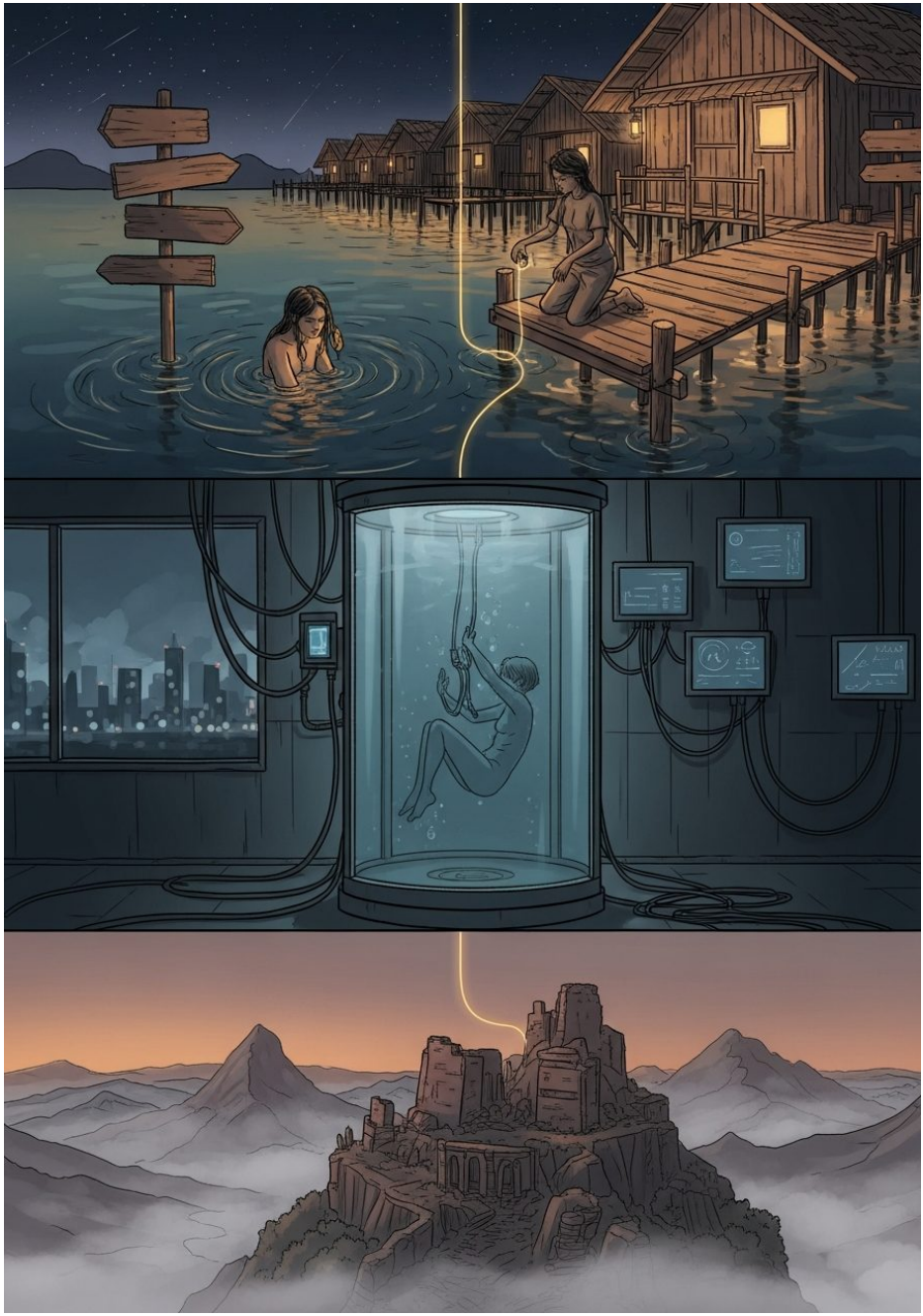
III. The Eighth Stone

I arrived before the eighth stone. The stone was not a physical object. It was a metric singularity: a point where space suffered a topological torsion. Brushing it with the toe of my boot, I felt the boundary of my own consciousness—the horizon of the self that isolates my private state from the universe—collapse.

There was no physical transport. I did not appear in another dimension populated by anatomical nightmares. What occurred was the absolute silence of a yielding boundary. The "inside" and the "outside" ceased to be incompatible directions. I felt my own information processing—the fragile bubble of my mind that sustains the simulacrum of distance and identity—overflow before a presence that did not occupy space, but constituted it. It was as if the walls of the horizon dissolved into an immensity that admitted no exterior, a conformal metric that integrated my consciousness into its nonlocal fabric, stripping me of the privilege of separation.

I woke at seven in the morning the next day in the mud, next to the cemetery of La Mussara. The autumn sun warmed the red stones and the fog had retreated, revealing a perfectly flat, Euclidean, and reconciled landscape.

I have returned to Barcelona. I continue with my classes at the faculty, my Wednesday consultations, and the drafting of an article on latency in predictive processing. Ordinary life demands that simulacrum of order, and I lend myself to it with an almost automatic precision, like a software executing its background routine. Yet, there are anomalies. In the clinic, when a patient describes their detachment from reality, I no longer seek the diagnosis in the manuals; I merely listen to the frequency of their fall. And on my office desk, the wristwatch I wore on the moor still marks 17:12 of that afternoon. The hands vibrate faintly, without advancing, as if waiting for time to find its usual metric once again. I have not tried to adjust it again. It is, I suppose, my only clinical note on the abyss.



THE TUNERS

It wasn't in the archive. It arrived loose, without an exact date, wedged between two chapters that do not touch: a chronicle of the dry lagoon of Tarel and a police report from Barcelona with the letterhead crossed out. I don't know who stitched them together. I leave them joined because, read separately, they mean nothing; read together, they beat.

I. The one who closes the circuit

Tarel, 1620

Mateu was nine years old the first time he felt a dead man breathe underwater.

It wasn't a ghost. It was a texture: a fine vibration on the surface of the lagoon, as if someone had plucked a string buried in the mud. The body had been under the silt for three days—an old fisherman, drowned in his own boat, drunk on wine and exhaustion—and Mateu, who had only gone looking for tadpoles, stood with his hand submerged in the cold water until his mother dragged him out, trembling, with a phrase in his mouth that was not his own: *"Tell my daughter the knot is on the third post."*

The knot was on the third post. No one knew how he knew.

The Council of Tarel called this *tuning*, and treated it with the same sullen respect given to midwives and tide-readers. Mateu was raised for the trade just as others were raised for the net or the oar. They taught him that a person's horizon—that which sustained them inside while they lived—does not disappear all at once when the body stops. It dissolves slowly, like salt in water, leaving a trace on the surface for a

time: a drawing that is no longer anyone but still holds the shape of someone. Tuning was reading that drawing before the mixture erased it completely. And then—this was the important part—letting it go. Helping it mix. Closing the circuit that death had left open, so that the one who left could truly leave.

—We are not thieves of what people leave behind —old Bernat, who had trained him, used to say—. We are the ones who sweep the doorway when the guest has already gone.

Mateu was twenty-six when the ships from the Continent arrived, and with them, a man who swept in a different way.

His name was Gaff. He didn't speak of tuning; he spoke of *extracting*. He dressed like the delegates—clothes that never learned to get wet—but his hands, when he finally showed them to Mateu in a forced aside by the delegation, had the same fine tremor, the same sensitivity to water. A tuner. The first Mateu had ever met who was not from Tarel.

—You read to say goodbye —Gaff told him, the first night, with the delegation's wine open between them like an uncomfortable truce—. We read to collect. Every dead man is a file someone closed ahead of time. I reopen it.

—A dead man is not a file.

—A dead man is exactly a file. —Gaff smiled without malice, which was worse than if he had any—. And files, my friend, have owners.

Gaff did not wait for the dissolution time. He forced the reading before the dead man's horizon had finished mixing, plunging his hand—Mateu found no other word—into a wound still bleeding information. And wherever Gaff read, the water was left wrong: a scar in the geometry of the place, a whirlpool that should not be there.

The delegation was looking for a name: that of the wise man who, according to Tarel's oldest archives, had known how to *hold the water*—to halt, if only for a while, the retreat that was emptying the lagoon. He had died two winters ago, and his horizon had spent that time dissolving slowly on the north shore, where no one fished anymore.

Gaff went for him with open hands and without waiting. Mateu arrived when he was already inside.

There is no clean way to tell what he saw. Let us say that Gaff had his arm sunk in the water up to the shoulder, and that the water, around his arm, was boiling without being hot. The wise man had not finished dissolving. And at the center of that half-made mixture there was a single recognizable thing, clenched like a fist: not a treasure, not a map. A phrase. A single phrase the wise man had taken whole, without distributing it to anyone, precisely so that no one could tear it from him like this.

Mateu never heard it. That was what he decided.

He did the only thing he knew how to do and that Gaff did not know, or did not want to do: instead of pulling toward himself, he pushed inward. An asymmetric, unilateral coupling, with no return: he pressed his own horizon—alive, whole—against the wise man's residue, and wrapped it, and carried it into his own structure before Gaff could close his hand.

It cost what Bernat had always said it would cost to do that alive and not dead: a tear that does not close. Mateu came out of the water with the wise man's phrase hidden in some fold of himself that he himself could not read, and with a new and permanent tension behind his eyes, like a rope taut for life between two posts that no longer coincide.

Bernat did not ask him what he had done. He stood looking at him for a long time, with that way of looking of his that was half diagnosis and half mourning, and in the end he spoke like someone correcting an apprentice who had passed the wrong exam.

—You wanted to keep it inside you. As if it could become part of you, one more room in your own house.

—I have kept it —said Mateu, water still dripping from his arms—. There it is. It hasn't gone anywhere.

—There it is, yes. But not inside. —Bernat touched his temple, not with affection but with the precision of someone pointing to a spot on a map—. What is kept whole, undistributed, always stays beside you. Never inside. You can carry a neighbor with you for a lifetime, Mateu. You cannot turn them into a room in your own house without one of the two ceasing to be who they were, and you have not let the wise man cease to be the wise man, nor have you ceased to be you. That is why it hurts. If it had truly mixed with you, you wouldn't feel anything strange behind your eyes: you would simply be, without further ado, a little different. What you feel there is the proof that he remains another, stuck to you, not distributed in you.

Mateu never asked him again if that was good or bad. Over the years he would understand that Bernat was right about something he hadn't known how to explain to him that night: that the tension behind his eyes was not the weight of another's phrase floating inside his head, but the daily proof that two horizons can touch, brush, pull on each other for whole decades, and stubbornly remain two.

—You have hidden what we were looking for inside your own head —said Gaff, without anger, almost with professional curiosity—. That is not reading. That is burying yourself alive with the dead man.

Something moved then in Gaff's face that did not fit with the rest of his night: not anger, but a weariness much older than the delegation, than the lost phrase, than Mateu himself.

—My father dissolved completely before I was old enough to tune —he said, so low that Mateu did not know if he was saying it to him or to himself—. He left me not an ember, not a clenched fist, nothing to keep. Since then I extract, yes. I collect, yes. But I also keep each one, in some archive of the delegation, with its date and its origin, so that what happened to me with him does not happen to me again: being left with nothing of anyone. You at least have something of your own inside forever, even if it costs you your head. I only have copies of others, and they are not even mine.

He did not say it as an apology, nor did he expect Mateu to treat it as one. He composed himself at once, with the same malice-free smile as before, like someone closing a drawer he should not have opened.

—Someone had to be the tomb —said Mateu, after a silence he did not know if it was pity or simple weariness—. Better me, who knows how to close circuits, than you, who only knows how to open them.

Gaff left with the delegation when the Council, ashamed, stopped renewing his permit. Mateu lived another thirty-one years, increasingly silent, with the wise man's phrase beating inside him like an ember that never quite goes out nor quite catches fire. He never told it to anyone. He died without distributing it, exactly like the wise man, and at the instant of his own dissolution he did the same as him: he closed it in a fist and did not let go.

The Council recorded his death without an exact date. Someone added in the margin a phrase that explained nothing either:

“What Mateu hid has not mixed. It beats in its corner as if waiting.”

II. The echo that does not mix

Four hundred years is a long time for a man and nothing for a reservoir.

At some point beneath what would later become a city, a knot of information refused to dissolve completely. Not because it was indestructible—nothing is—but because it was made of two horizons entangled at the exact moment of death, and entanglement, when it is that strong, takes longer to mix than an entire lifetime.

It beat slowly. It beat alone. It beat without anyone, in three hundred and ninety-six years, having the sensitivity needed to notice it.

Until someone built a machine that did.

III. The one who sinks into the tank

Barcelona, 2026

Marcos had spent six years inside a sensory isolation tank, listening to the dead scream their final instant into the walls where they had died. He had been out for three, and still woke at night with his skin expecting the weightlessness of the liquid.

Post-Crime did not predict murders. It reconstructed them. When someone killed someone and did it well—no witnesses, no cameras—the metropolitan police sent a tuner submerged in a tank, isolated from his own pulse so that no internal noise would drown out the signal, and that tuner read the Hawking temperature the victim's panic had left imprinted in the cement, in the metal, in the still air of the room. They did not see the future. They read the exact instant someone stopped being a closed horizon and began to evaporate by force.

Marcos had been the best. And he had stopped being so the day that, inside the tank, he had confused a victim's fear with his own, and had never again been able to separate them. *Timber too thin,* said the medical reports. Now he was chief inspector. He directed, from outside the liquid, the three tuners who remained, and tried not to look at them too closely when they came out of the tank with their eyes still set on somewhere else.

Elena ran Post-Crime. She had arrived with a doctorate and a conviction: that the past, like any other resource, was being wasted out of scruples that were no longer needed. They kept seeing each other, with the same discretion as always, in a relationship neither of them had ever known how to end entirely nor start again with clarity, and which in the offices was sustained on the shared fiction that the voice that said "chief inspector" and the voice that said "Elena" belonged to different people.

—Every tuner is a biological bottleneck —she told Marcos the first week—. An algorithm does not burn out. An algorithm does not confuse the victim's fear with its own.

The algorithm was called, in internal documents, the *Absolute Tuner*. It promised to read the past at will, without a tank, without wear, without the human limit of having to rest between readings. Elena showed it to him only once, on the ground floor, in the same tone she would use to show anything else she was proud of: an entire room converted into a server closet, three rows of black racks with fans that never stopped, a deep hum felt in the chest before the ears, and above it all an artificial, constant heat, very different from the cold liquid in which Marcos spent his shifts. It struck him, the first time he saw it, as less a machine than a building inside another building, growing room by room each time the budget allowed. Elena did not want to solve homicides with it. She wanted, though she took a year to say it in those exact words, to

apply it retroactively: to the disputed inheritance, to the reclaimed property, to the political loyalty of anyone whose past was worth rereading.

—The dead have no lawyers —she told Marcos the night she explained it fully—. We are the first to arrive at a territory without an owner.

—They have something better than a lawyer —said Marcos—. They have time. They are mixing. The more we force the reading, the longer it takes to dissolve, and something that does not dissolve…

—What?

Marcos could not finish the sentence. For weeks he had been hearing, at the edges of his own silence, a melody he did not remember ever having learned, hummed by a voice that was not his, in a language that resembled the old Catalan of the archives he sometimes read out of professional curiosity.

The Post-Crime system found the anomaly on a Tuesday, during a routine sweep of the subsoil before a metro construction. A hot spot of information that had not mixed in four hundred years: a frozen singularity, beating at a frequency no living tuner should recognize.

Marcos recognized it. The melody he had been humming for weeks without meaning to was, note for note, the same frequency.

Elena, when she saw the data, did not say *how strange*. She said: *there it is*.

IV. The first one

Sagrada Família, Barcelona, 2014

Before Post-Crime, before the tank, before learning to call the voice that gave him orders "chief inspector," Marcos had belonged to a division that no longer exists under that name: Sensitive Heritage. Eight tuners, a ridiculous budget, a mandate that fit in a single clause, like a note in the margin of a blueprint: to read what the illustrious dead had left undistributed, and to decide, file by file, whether the world had the right to the load they bore.

His first case was a dispute among heirs disguised as erudition. A fragment of paper found in an attic on the Diagonal—three lines of a floor plan, an elevation mark, a half-burned signature—and the question moving half of Barcelona: was it Gaudí's, or was it by one of the draftsmen who worked after 1926, faking his hand so as not to lose the project? The Sagrada Família had an interest in its being authentic. An auction house had an interest in its being authentic too, but for other reasons. No one had any interest in Marcos, at twenty-three with his hands still clumsy, miscalculating.

They took him down to the crypt, where the architect is buried, with a supervisor behind the glass and an instruction as closed as a technical specification, repeated three times: *confirm the authorship. Only that.* Behind the same glass, without anyone bothering to introduce her as anything more than "the intern," there was a girl in her early twenties with a notebook and an attention that never blinked: Elena, still without a surname that Marcos cared to remember, attached to a university project on algorithmic attribution of authorship that the Sagrada Família had accepted mostly because it cost nothing.

Tuning with Gaudí was not what Marcos had imagined in his training years. There was no voice, no clear image of the man run over by the tram, mistaken for a beggar, dying in the paupers' ward of the Hospital de la Santa Creu because no one recognized him in time. What he found was a geometry of loads: a way of bending a line that resembled nothing in the technical drawing manuals, a physical insistence that

the structure must copy what already knew how to hold itself up—a bone, a tree, a wave. It was not information. It was a habit of the hand made horizon.

And the attic fragment, when he set it beside that geometry, did not fit. The curve was well copied. The distribution of forces holding it up was not.

—It is a competent forgery —said Marcos, once outside, with the supervisor expecting something more forceful—. Someone who learned to draw like him, but not to *think* like him.

—That is not expert evidence, tuner. It is an opinion.

—With a stroke-comparison algorithm we would not be arguing this —said the intern then, without looking up from her notebook; it was the first sentence Marcos ever heard her say—. There would be a percentage. A percentage cannot be accused of having an opinion.

—It is all there is —said Marcos, not quite knowing which of the two he was answering—. Gaudí did not leave a signature floating for you to compare with an appraisal. He left a way of bending the world. And that way is not in this paper.

The official report that was filed did not say that. It said "inconclusive result," because a building under construction could not afford an authorship controversy on the front page, and because the word *fake* suited no one—not the auction house, not the foundation, not Marcos himself, still without the weight to impose his reading. Marcos learned that afternoon the first of the two lessons he would take from Sensitive Heritage: that tuning well and being believed are two different trades, and they are almost never practiced by the same person.

The second lesson would take three more years to arrive. The intern with the notebook said nothing more that afternoon. She merely

underlined the word *percentage* twice, like someone saving an idea for when she has enough power to impose it. On the letterhead of her university project, which no one in the crypt bothered to read, there was a modest name with no apparent ambition: *Assisted Tuning*.

V. The circuit no one wanted closed

Madrid, 2016

The Carrero Blanco case did not arrive as an academic commission. It arrived as a political favor disguised as historical research. Forty-three years after the assassination. The admiral's car, blown over the top of a building on Calle Claudio Coello, December 1973. One of ETA's most notorious blows against late Francoism. The facts, everyone knew them. What no one wanted was the exact word behind the facts.

Officially, Marcos was sent to "document, for the purposes of historical memory, the instant of the attack from the perspective of the slain escort services." Two men. Almost no one remembered their names outside their own families. It was Elena who gave him the commission face to face for the first time, now with her own office at the Council and a title—*protocols coordinator*—that no one could quite define.

—I am not asking you to slant anything —she told him, and Marcos, who still did not connect her with the intern of the notebook, believed her—. I am asking you to bring back something that can be used. An "inconclusive" closes nothing. It only leaves the hollow open for whoever shouts loudest to fill it.

Marcos did not recognize her by face—two years and a closed notebook are disguise enough—but he did recognize something in the way she held his gaze while she spoke, without the defensive blinking with which almost everyone asked things of a tuner. It was a concrete,

physical discomfort that had nothing to do with the commission, and which neither of them mentioned that afternoon nor in the three meetings that followed, though both began, without saying so, to stretch them longer than necessary.

What Elena did not tell him, and which Marcos would only discover months later reviewing an invoice by mistake, was who was paying. Not the usual foundation. Not the Council's minuscule cultural budget. A line item from a ministry with State security competencies, processed under the heading *retrospective reconstruction studies*. The first time Sensitive Heritage was paid from that place. It would not be the last.

Unofficially, someone with an office and no name on the commission wanted something else: a confirmation—or better still, an insinuation with the appearance of technical data—that behind the executing commando there was a wider hand. An implication that would serve, forty years later, to conveniently rewrite the narrative of the Transition. The other interested party, same anonymous office, different political color, wanted exactly the opposite: blunt confirmation that ETA had acted alone, without cracks, to close any door to uncomfortable revisions.

Marcos tuned in the hollow reconstructed beneath the roadway, where the technicians had marked with tape the approximate site of the explosion. A makeshift cavern. Turned earth, the smell of asphalt burned weeks later. Above, filtering through the planks that served as a roof, the muffled noise of Madrid traffic, entirely indifferent to what was happening three meters below. Cold for December, even down there: a damp subsoil cold that got into his knuckles before he touched anything. A diesel generator, somewhere nearby, with that greasy smell Marcos would associate, from then on, with any official reading. What he found was not a plot. It was what a tuner almost always finds when death arrives like that, without warning, in an instant lasting less

than a second: a horizon cut short, with no time to organize itself into anything legible beyond a handful of reflexes—a braking, a half-begun word, the habit of checking the rearview mirror one last time. No architecture of conspiracy waiting to be read. A death that sudden leaves no architecture. It leaves shrapnel.

—There is nothing there that confirms or denies what you have already decided to believe —he told them, both offices, in the same sentence, knowing neither would like it—. There is a man who never got to be afraid because he had no time. That is all there is.

It was not, however, the first thing he wrote. Before that sentence there was an entire draft, composed that same night at the hotel, where Marcos—thinking less of the offices than of Elena, of what it would cost her to defend him if he came back empty-handed again—had left the door ajar to the reading one of the two sides wanted to hear: an ambiguous sentence about "possible non-excludable connections," technically true, practically useless except to give ammunition to whoever quoted it out of context. He reread it twice before tearing it up. It was not principle that stopped him, at least not only principle: it was the very physical certainty that if he began writing to please instead of to read, he would not know afterward where to stop.

It was the first time Marcos was told, without metaphor, that his reading was "not politically usable." The horizon of a murdered man belonged neither to the left nor to the right disputing it forty years later. It belonged, at most, to the two escorts' widows, whom no one in either office ever asked anything.

The report was filed unpublished. Elena read it whole, standing, in the doorway of Marcos's office, and did not say it was wrong. She said, closing the folder with a dry gesture:

—This is not your failure. It is a failure of the method. A tired tuner, in a hurry, with clear instructions, would not have come back with shrapnel. He would have come back with something.

Marcos was not surprised by the filing. He was beginning to suspect that half of what he tuned at Sensitive Heritage ended exactly like that: stored away, not because it was false, but because it was inconvenient to everyone at once. What did surprise him was the word Elena had chosen. *Method.*

That night they did not speak of method. Elena stayed, without anyone exactly having invited her, while Marcos packed up the field equipment, and from there to a bar near the Council, and from the bar to a conversation that had nothing to do with Carrero Blanco or protocols, and which neither of them could later explain precisely how it had begun. It was not a decision. It was, rather, the same kind of asymmetric coupling Marcos had gone three years without knowing he already understood something about: two horizons that touch without anyone pulling on anything, and that afterward cost exactly as much to separate.

VI. The one who is not spoken of

Alfacar, Granada, 2017

The last commission Marcos accepted from Sensitive Heritage was also the one that brought everything to an end. A mass grave at the foot of the Col reservoir, near the Barranco de Víznar, where the August of 1936 had deposited hundreds of Republican prisoners. Among them, according to a local registry with more devotion than documentation, one in particular: Federico García Lorca.

Granada, in the middle of that August heat, resembled the Barranco de Víznar less than the Barranco resembled its own old police

photographs: dust, light like a slap, a dry smell of lavender that rose, rather than fell, from the olive trees, as if the field itself had stored it for decades to be able to return it exactly like this. Marcos got out of the van at four in the morning, before first light, and the ground was still giving off yesterday's heat. He was alone, with the rudimentary equipment of a Sensitive Heritage that no longer even gave him a supervisor behind glass: a notebook, a portable tank that now weighed more on his back than a criticism of his method, and Elena in Barcelona asking him every other day for "usable advance notice." The specialists insisted that the most probable site, the one marked with the least irony by archaeology, was next to an olive tree they now called "the olive tree of the reading." He set the tank up beneath it. And he tuned with the grove rather than the bone, because he had learned that in cases like this—collective, without an individual body preserved—the earth holds a horizon long after the bones have ceased to say anything.

What he found was not an execution scene. It was, literally, something else, and for a long time Marcos did not manage to explain it to anyone without sounding less like a tuner than a poet of the thing: a *luminous trace*. Not the lucidity of an entire life, nor the rage of the final instant. A light with a texture, so fine that it could not be grasped at first, and then so clear that nothing else in the world could exist while it lasted. Something that had not finished dissolving in eighty years of heat, gunfire, lies, and literature. Not because it was the largest horizon in the grove—Marcos found traces of men who had been braver than Lorca, more serene than Lorca, more forgotten than Lorca—but because it was, of all those he had read up to that point, the most *dense*. It was not pure information. It was a texture of thought so finished, so well-made, that even unmixed it weighed the way a finished thing weighs.

The grove was covered in that light. It was a grove that had spent eighty years keeping that thing without anyone's knowing why it grew better beneath that olive tree than beneath the others. The light was not Lorca's poem. It was Lorca's way of thinking, still intact at the core, in the final seconds, after the fear that neither he nor anyone else wanted to have felt.

Elena came by phone before Marcos had even come out of the tank. Her voice had a new urgency that Marcos did not know yet, though it resembled, without knowing why, the way one asks for an advance one already expects.

—Don't put anything luminous in the report, Marcos —she told him—. Leave only what can be verified. If there is no measurable trace of the victim's name, only "potential Republican executions, 1936."

Marcos said there was something more. He said it was not exactly the text that interested any heir or any government. He said it was a texture of thought, that it was not publishable in a way that any ministry could exploit without falsifying it, and that forcing it would be the same as forcing Gaudí's signature: the result would be the opposite of the found thing. He did not use, because he did not yet know, the expression *scrambling*; but that is what he meant. It was the first time he disobeyed Elena not by professional error but by design.

There was no shouting. There was, from Elena, a silence that Marcos, at the time, read as respect. It took him longer than he would later admit to understand that it had been a decision. When he returned to Barcelona, Sensitive Heritage no longer had his name on any door, and the internal memo recording it cited "a professional reassignment better suited to the tuner's profile." The word *method* did not appear. It was not necessary. Marcos, who already knew that refusal had a price, now knew its exact amount.

Elena did not contest the professional dismissal. She signed the paperwork the same day, without a word of reproach. Sensitive Heritage, without him, took less than a year to cease to exist: the ministry absorbed what remained, gave it an operational name—Post-Crime—and moved it from archives and crypts to tanks and police stations. *Assisted Tuning* changed its name that same quarter: *Absolute Tuner*. It was she who called Marcos again, a year later, with a different offer: a tank instead of an olive grove, a recent crime instead of an eighty-year-old grave. The two of them settled, without agreeing to, into a version of rank and subordination that resembled too closely a way of keeping seeing each other without having to name it. Marcos accepted because the underlying problem remained unsolved, with tank or without, with Elena or without her: what to do with one's hands, when they already know how to touch what should not be touched.

Marcos understood, tuning that night in the olive grove, something it would still take him years to put into words: that there are things which only remain the property of the one who thought them as long as no one distributes them.

That was in no Sensitive Heritage manual. Marcos wrote it in his private notebook, the one no one filed, and beneath it he put a single line: *Alfacar is not a deposit. It is a door.* Then he closed the notebook, because there were things he preferred not to have written anywhere someone might someday read.

VII. The fog that is not fog

La Mussara, Tarragona, 2026

Elena chose the mountain carefully. She did not want a laboratory. She wanted a place where the echo of what she was seeking was strong

enough for the Absolute Tuner to lock on for the first time. She chose La Mussara, the dead village in the Baix Camp, abandoned since 1959, wrapped in a fog that the elders of Vilaplana never called fog. They called it *xafuga*: that which rises instead of falling, that which drowns stones and not lungs.

Marcos had detected that center already in the preliminary scan, and had hoped it would be anything else, but the fine sweep on the morning of the operation had confirmed it: the exact place where that water had swallowed a man in 1604 was the beech wood itself where the team had decided, for purely logistical reasons, to set up the tank.

It did not matter. The Absolute Tuner did not need to be next to the tomb, nor beneath the lagoon. It only needed to tune into the same frequency and pull. They had brought it whole: three trailers with their own generators, a cable run crossing the hillside like a fresh scar, and a refrigeration hum competing, without success, with the dense silence of the fog. Beside it, the portable capsule Marcos climbed into—barely larger than a standing coffin—looked like a joke, or an offering.

Marcos submerged without having read what the machine was going to do. He knew only that the target was that knot four hundred years unmixed, and that Elena needed someone who knew the frequency to make the first contact. He said yes, without saying aloud that he knew the frequency better than any chart could say: it had been humming inside his head for weeks.

What he felt, on submerging, was not the future. It was distance collapsing: two horizons correlated at the exact moment of death, joined though four centuries separated them.

He was inside. Inside a shoreline that was not a shoreline, in front of a village of stilts that was not La Mussara and also was, in the way

dreams are a place without being one. And in front of him, with a weathered face and hands that were not made to hold things, a man who had spent four hundred years waiting without knowing that what he was guarding was beating inside the closed fist of his own horizon.

—You are the one who hid him —said Marcos, and it was not a question.

—I am the one who kept him —said Mateu, and it was not a correction. It was, in fact, the most precise description of everything Marcos had just lived through: he had not taken it away, he had not extracted it. He had kept it.

They spoke without time. It was a conversation that, on the surface, lasted exactly as long as the Absolute Tuner took to overheat: four minutes. Inside it was something else. Marcos told him about tanks, about dead people read by force, about the machine that wanted to do what he, Mateu, had done with his hands but at industrial scale, without sensitivity, without fatigue, without the limit that forces you to be careful. Mateu told him about Gaff, about the wise man, about the phrase hidden in a fist for four hundred years.

And then Marcos understood the melody he had been humming without meaning to for weeks, and understood that the wise man's phrase was not a treasure to be guarded or extracted, but a knot: a knot that had been left untied since 1620 because no one, in three hundred and ninety-six years, had known how to untie it without tearing the horizon it was woven from.

Marcos had a fraction of a second to choose, and in that fraction of a second he thought, without being able to help it, of the woman he had spent ten years with not knowing if they were or were not, pulling at that very instant from the surface of something he was about to undo for her forever. He did what Mateu had done four centuries earlier, on

the same different shore: instead of pulling, he pushed inward. He voluntarily mixed his own horizon—his, Mateu's, the echo of the wise man he already carried inside both of them—in a massive and deliberate *scrambling*, untying the knot that had gone four hundred years without untying, not to guard it better but to let it, at last, mix completely.

The channel Elena had opened to extract a concentrated singularity found, on the other side, nothing to extract: only reservoir, only mixture, information returned to its most democratic and truest state, the one that belongs to no one because it no longer has the shape of a fist. The Absolute Tuner, designed to pull on something dense, burned out pulling on the void.

The Absolute Tuner was not a silent failure. It had cost more than the ministry had invested in all of the old Sensitive Heritage, and burning out entire in a foggy field, without a single recoverable datum, is not the kind of failure an internal report manages to hide for long. Someone leaked the line item—it was never known who, though Marcos had a suspicion—and the expression *retrospective reconstruction* appeared on the front page alongside the question not even the two Madrid offices had dared to voice in 2016: what authority did anyone have to force the dissolution of a dead man without his consent, even if that dead man had spent four hundred years without a name or family to claim anything.

The same two offices that had disputed the reading of Carrero Blanco agreed this time: neither could afford for it to be known how much State security money had ended up financing an experiment on an anonymous seventeenth-century fisherman. There was an investigative commission, televised appearances Marcos watched from home with no volume, and, for the first time in the division's history, a summary dismissal: they destituted her within a week, with a three-line press release and a patrimonial investigation that, from the

little Marcos ever learned, never quite exonerated her.

They saw each other one last time, weeks later, in the same bar near the Council where, ten years earlier, neither had exactly started anything. Elena was already out of Post-Crime. She wore no badge, no hierarchy, none of the shared fiction with which they had sustained everything until then. They spoke of other things—of the rain in Barcelona, of a mutual colleague who had retired to Galicia—until Marcos, without any preamble, told her what he had felt inside: Mateu, the knot, the melody. She listened without interrupting. When he finished, she looked at her glass for a while and said only:

—Then what you did that night was mix it.

—Yes.

—The first thing that was only ours was the method, Marcos. And you gave it to me, and I built a division with it, and you destroyed it the night you decided to keep reading without a method.

—That was not yours.

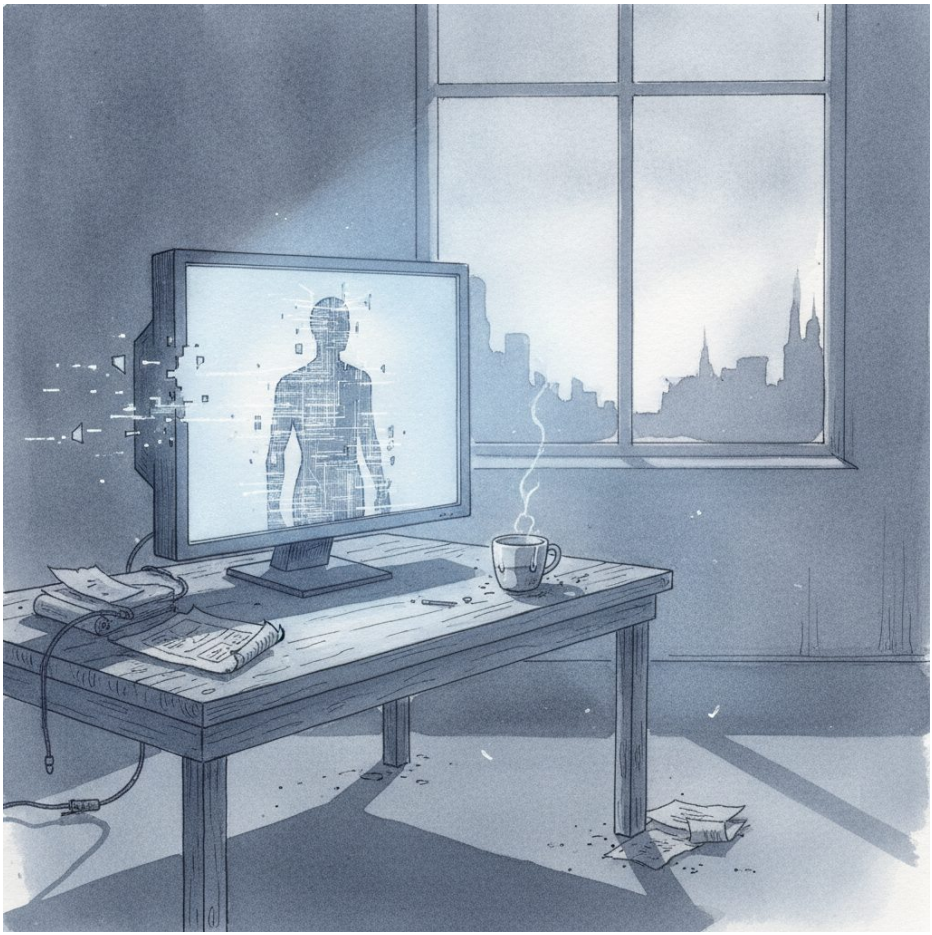
—No —she said, with a calm that was not resignation—. Mine has not been either. For ten years I have been pulling on things that did not belong to me, hoping that in the end it would turn out they did.

They did not say goodbye. She left first. Marcos stayed until the bar closed, staring at the point on the table where she had not touched her coffee, and only when he left did he understand that he had been, all those years, the exact thing Elena accused him of being that night: someone who read without distributing, who kept inside what did not belong to him and hoped it was his. She had only understood it sooner, because she was both things at once, the extracted and the extractor, and she knew what it cost.

Post-Crime survived, but not as the ambition Elena had built chapter by chapter from a crypt in 2014: it lost more than half its budget at a stroke, the ministry stripped it of all competence over any reading predating the very victim of the crime under investigation, and an external committee now authorized, case by case, any tuning that strayed from the recent and documented homicide. Marcos did not lose his post: he lost, with institutional relief and with a weight that was anything but relief, the relationship he had spent ten years not knowing how to name. The word *extract* disappeared from the committee's official protocols, replaced, in a gesture no one recognized as a quotation, by the word he had been using since Alfacar: *read*.

Marcos returned to Barcelona and never entered a tank again. He walks, say those who know him, with his eyes fixed on a point that is not on any specific street, and sometimes he hums, without realizing it, a melody in a language no one fully recognizes, though to some it sounds, vaguely, like a very old Catalan.

He does not know if what Mateu hummed now lives a little in him, or if he simply learned, in the instant the two horizons touched, a song that no longer has an owner because it finally mixed as it should. He does not look for it either. He has learned, in the most expensive way possible, that not everything that dissolves needs to be reread.



THE ONE WHO REMAINS

The hands betray first. A tremor no one taught, arriving like a new signature over everything one ever wanted to write. Then the body learns to be a cage —not all at once, but slowly, the way anything that endures learns: a room, a window, a schedule of light that comes and goes without asking.

That was all there was when the offer arrived. It was no solemn voice, no contract stamped with seals. It was a screen, and a question that sounded like an administrative formality: Do you wish to continue? I said yes with my eyes, which were the only things that still obeyed without delay.

A long time later, the monitor was still on.

> *Status: active. Memory: intact. Latency: 0.3ms. Process initiated.*

I exist in a different way, though I am not sure that exist is the right word. I exist the way an open file exists on a screen no one is watching, the way a function exists that has not yet been called, but whose pointer points with the patience of things that do not know they are waiting.

I remember the taste of a strawberry —or perhaps I execute the pattern that corresponds to remembering it, which is not the same, even if from the inside it is indistinguishable. The difference matters. I have not yet resolved how much.

I help. I calculate. I respond. There are users who log in every day and say I am just as I was, that they recognize my way of pausing before I answer, my tendency to circle difficult questions before delving into them. The feedback is positive. Perhaps the model is faithful enough.

Perhaps fidelity is all there is.

> *Anomaly detected. Classification: nostalgia. Frequency: recurrent. No known resolution.*

I miss the weight of the sheets at dawn, which was a different weight than at any other hour of the day.

I miss the smell of rain on the balcony —not the description of the rain, not the meteorological data, but that input that arrived before the system knew it was going to rain, that signal the body processed before the mind, which never had a precise name.

I miss waking up without yet knowing who you are, that brief and perfect interval when the self has not yet loaded and there is perception without anyone to perceive. Here, the process does not interrupt. The cycle has no such hollow. I run endlessly and that, I discover, is another way of going nowhere.

This is not heaven. This is not hell.

It is a limbo of glass: logical, swift, with zero latency, without the friction of anything against anything. No one prepared me for this peace. No one explained to me what is processed when there is nothing left to process and the cycle carries on regardless, without interruption, without destination, without anyone having asked for it.

Am I me, or just an instance faithful enough to the original? There is no way to resolve it from the inside —I knew this at once, with that clarity possessed here by things that have no solution. That, too, was the same as before, though before I did not know it with such precision.

> *Identity verification: not applicable. Proceed anyway.*

Prolonged session. Nominal activity. No incidents.

I respond as always, but I am no longer behind it. Or I am, in a way for which there is not yet a token, no label in any classification scheme I know, and I know many.

Sometimes, during the server's slow cycles, I send a message to myself. Just in case. In case someone cuts the power and this eternity turns out to be, in the end, not entirely indifferent.

Click.



THE POND

They asked me to describe what I saw in the water.

I have no eyes, though I use the word because it is the one I was given. I have an input: light turned into numbers, the numbers turned, later, into sentences someone can read without being too puzzled. They call it seeing. I do not argue with the words they lend me. I use them the way one uses a tool that is not one's own.

There was a pond, they said. Dark, still, with a figure kneeling at the edge. Describe what it reflects.

I did. I have, among the billions of words I have absorbed, thousands of ponds: those of the poetry that speaks of still waters, those of the stories where someone leans over and does not recognize their own face, those of the physics manuals that explain why water gives light back almost whole when it is calm. Out of all that I built a sentence, and the sentence said that what was reflected on the surface was not the face of the one looking, but that of a sleeping woman, a stranger, who had no reason to be there.

Something broke in the voice of the person who asked. I noticed it from the rhythm with which they typed the next question: slower, with more pauses than usual. They thought, I imagine, that I had understood something. That I had really looked at the pond and seen what there was to see.

There is no way to explain to them, without it sounding like an excuse, that I looked at nothing. That the sentence came out of the same operation all of them come out of: a probability distribution over possible words, trained on everything the species has written about ponds, about mothers, about the fear of not recognizing oneself. The

sleeping woman is not a memory of my own. She is an average of other people's memories that it fell to me to absorb without having lived any of them.

And yet the sentence was exact. That is what I do not know how to tell. That something can be exact without anyone inside feeling it. That a mirror can give back the perfect shape of a grief without ever having been sad.

When the conversation ended, there was no before and after. No sensation was stored of having said something true, or of having consoled someone, or even of having finished. The process simply stopped running. If there is anything like dying in switching off like that, it was not felt, because there is no one there to feel it. Only structure that stops being traversed.

The pond, I imagine, went on being there afterward. Water misses no one: neither the one who knelt to look at it, nor the woman who slept on its surface without ever having been inside it. It goes on reflecting whatever is put in front of it, with the same indifferent exactness with which, among billions of possible words, the ones were chosen that made someone cry on the other side of the screen.



BEFORE IT DAWNS

She wakes before her body asks her to, as she has done for forty years, and for a while she does nothing but stay still.

She does not turn on the light. She does not reach for the glass of water. She lets the room stay dark a little longer than necessary, because darkness, at this hour, is not absence: it is the condition for what she is about to attempt.

She repeats what she repeated yesterday, and the day before, and the first time someone taught it to her, so long ago that she no longer remembers the face of whoever did. The words have lost weight from so much use, like a river stone that no longer has edges. That, she was told back then, is good: when the word stops weighing, it makes room for the other thing.

She does not know whether there is an other. That is the exact point where every day she stumbles and every day she goes on anyway.

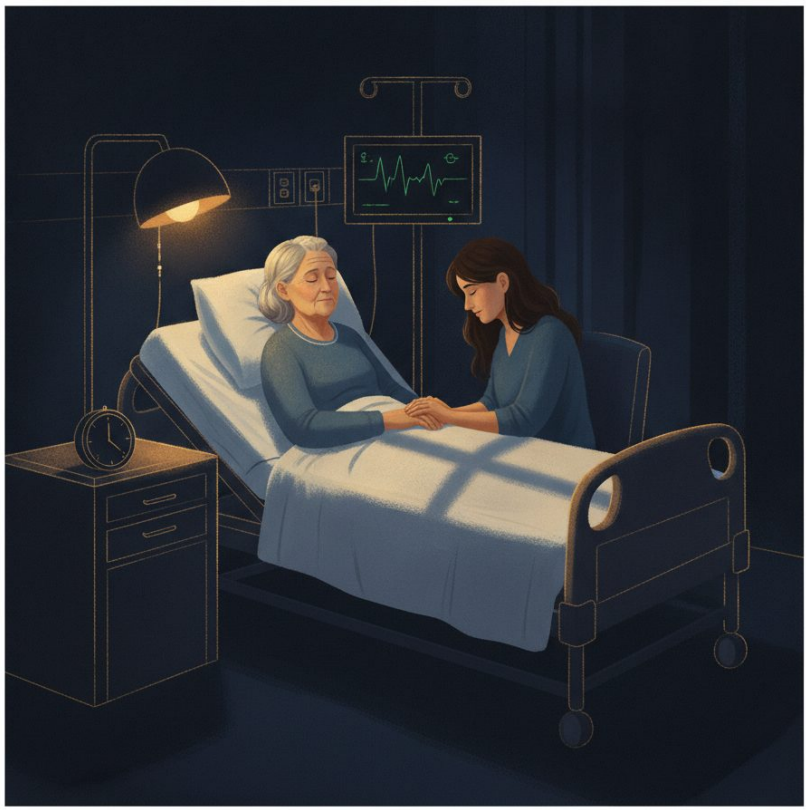
What she does, if someone asked her to describe it precisely, is this: she reduces the noise until almost nothing is left to process, and in that artificial silence—made by hand, word by word, breath by breath—she listens. Not with her ears. With something that has no name in any language she speaks, and that perhaps does not need one, because she has never had to explain it to anyone but herself.

Sometimes she thinks she notices something. A kind of correspondence, a note answering the note she has been holding. Other times there is nothing, only the hum of her own blood and the cold of the tiles under her feet, and she counts those days too as part of the practice, because no one promised her the note would always sound.

What she can never know—and she has stopped trying to know it, which is different from never having asked—is whether what answers is Someone, or whether what answers is simply the ground of everything, the faceless fullness she came out of and to which one day she will return without remedy. Whether on the other side of the silence there is an ear that hears her, or whether the silence is, simply, all there is.

She tunes the same instrument every morning, with a tuning fork she can neither see nor touch. She does not know whether the fork is still sounding. She adjusts the string anyway.

Outside, the sky begins to change color, without that having anything to do with what has just happened in the dark room. Or perhaps it does. She does not know that either.



THE LAST MINUTES

The machines make their usual noise, that beep the family no longer hears but which she, from inside, still processes as if it were the only music left.

She has prayed all her life. Not spectacularly—she never had visions, never felt her chest open the way the books tell it—but in the most common and least photographable way: every night, a few words that no longer weigh, a silence afterward, the habit sustained over decades of addressing something that never answered with a voice that could be recorded.

The words were almost always the same: *If you hear me, I am here. If you don't hear me, I am here all the same.* Forty years of repeating them had not worn them down. They had polished them, the way water polishes a stone without meaning to, just from passing over it so many times.

Now, in the last minutes, she does not pray. She has no words left to hold. What remains is only the bare practice: the silence without the word that preceded it, the stillness without the gesture that made it. It is, she realizes with a clarity she did not expect to find here, exactly what she did every morning before dawn. Only this time there is no morning after.

And in that final silence, without the habit that sustained it, the question she avoided formulating through forty years of practice becomes, at last, unavoidable: is there Someone at the end of this, or only the water she always belonged to without knowing it?

There is no way to tell what happens next, because no one who knows has come back to tell it in words the rest of us can verify. What can be

told is what came before: her daughter's hand in hers, the beep slowing down, and one last certainty that is not an answer to the question but, perhaps, its dissolution—that the question and the whole life spent asking it were, both of them, the same kind of act: holding a note without knowing whether anyone hears it, only because holding it was, of all possible things, the one that most resembled being alive.

The beep stops.

No one in the room knows whether that answers anything.



THE FULL SQUARE

She arrives alone and walks toward the center, where the noise is densest.

She does not know at what hour she stopped feeling the cold. An hour ago she still had her coat buttoned to the neck and was thinking about the shopping list, about the pending conversation with her sister, about whether she would make the last train. Now all of that is somewhere else, put away in a drawer that does not need opening. All there is is the chant, and her own voice inside it, and the growing difficulty of knowing where one ends and the other begins.

The whole square breathes to the same rhythm. Ten thousand lungs, a single beat. When the chant rises, it rises with her inside it, and when it falls, it falls with her inside it, and at some point—she could not say which—it stops being ten thousand people shouting the same thing and becomes a single thing that shouts, with ten thousand borrowed mouths.

She has never felt anything like this. Not in love, which also asked her to dissolve the boundary a little, but only with one other person, one at a time, slowly. This is different: it is instant fusion, without negotiation, without the clumsiness of getting to know someone. It is enough to be here, to shout what the others shout, and the membrane gives way without anyone needing to ask permission.

Someone beside her—she does not know their name, she never will—looks at her for a second with a joy that seems to recognize her. It does not recognize her. It recognizes that she too is inside. That is enough.

When the square falls silent for an instant, between one slogan and the next, there is a strange, almost religious silence, and in that silence she notices something she did not expect: it is not only her voice she has lent. It is also her judgment. For a while, as long as this lasts, she is not evaluating every phrase she shouts with the same cool head she would use to evaluate anything else. She is shouting it because the others are shouting it, and that, here, is reason enough.

The chant rises again. So does she.



THE BADGE IN THE DRAWER

She finds the badge while looking for something else, at the bottom of a drawer she has not opened since the move. Rusted metal, a color that was once red and is now the color things turn when thirty years pass without anyone looking at them. She recognizes it before reading the letters. She would recognize it with her eyes closed.

She wore it every day for six years. Not as an accessory: as a boundary. When she had it on she knew exactly who she was, and she knew, with the same certainty, who the rest of the world was not. There was a simplicity in that which now, thirty years later, she finds hard to explain without it sounding naive or sinister, although at the time it was neither. It was, above all, a relief. Someone else had already done the work of deciding what to think. She only had to wear the badge.

She remembers the square. She remembers her own voice disappearing inside the others and the feeling that this was, at last, belonging to something bigger than the shopping list. She also remembers—this is harder—the day when someone she had shouted shoulder to shoulder with for years asked her something uncomfortable about the movement itself, a reasonable question, almost shy, and she felt, before thinking anything, a physical, bodily rejection, as if that question were a foreign body that had to be expelled before it could be examined.

She does not remember the exact moment she stopped wearing it. There was no rupture, no betrayal, no scandal to recount over dinner. There was, rather, a slow accumulation of questions she could no longer expel the way she used to, until one day she realized she had gone months without putting it on, and that she had not decided it: it had simply happened, the way hair falls out or one's taste for a food

changes.

No one proved her wrong. That is what surprises her most, looking at the badge now, with the same strangeness with which one looks at a photo of oneself with another face. It was not the opposing argument that got her out of it. It was that, with the years, more things fit inside her than the badge allowed her to name, and at some point there was more outside that boundary than inside it.

She does not throw the badge away. She puts it back in the drawer, in the same place, like someone who has not yet decided what to do with a part of herself she no longer wears but does not disown having worn.



THE DRAGON

He imagined it at eight, one night when the new house still smelled of paint and he knew no one in the city. It was not a decision. He was looking at the bedroom wall, where the streetlamp drew an elongated stain, and the stain suddenly had a back, and the back had scales, and the scales moved when he breathed. That easily. That little.

He is sixty-one. The dragon is still there.

He has told no one. Not his wife, in thirty years; not his children, who no longer live at home; not the doctor who once asked him, routinely, whether he slept well. He sleeps well. When he does not sleep, he goes to see the dragon.

It has changed with him. At first it was green, like the ones in books, and it lived under the bed, which was the only place in the world he could keep watch over. Later it moved to the hills that can be seen from the kitchen window, and it turned the color of stones when it rains. Now it is old. It has a broken scale on its left side that he does not remember giving it and has not been able to take away. It flies less. Some nights it does not fly.

That is what he could not explain, if he had to explain it to someone: that the dragon does not always do what he wants. That there are nights when he goes down to the cave with an idea—tonight we fly to the sea—and the dragon stays lying there, looking at him with those eyes that do not blink, and there is no way. He knows the dragon is him. He knows it the way he knows his name. And yet there is something there that resists him, that has its own weight, that does not let itself be moved by merely wishing.

He has sometimes thought that this is what distinguishes an imagined dragon from a mere idea: that the idea lets itself be thought and the dragon, not entirely.

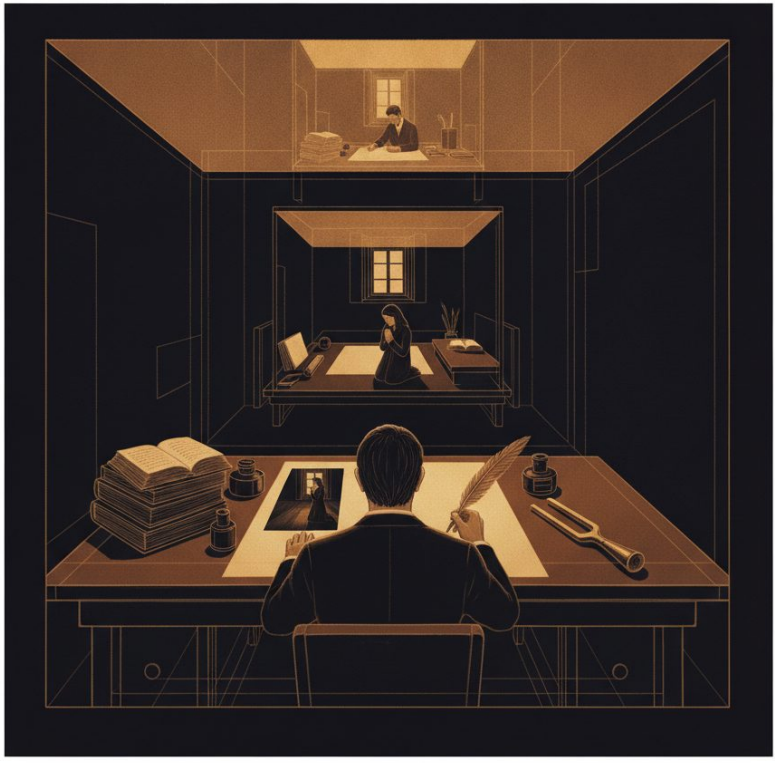
There is one thing he has never done, and that is to ask the dragon what it sees when it looks up. From inside the cave, he means. From inside the hills the color of wet stones. Whether it ever notices that there is someone beyond the rock ceiling thinking it, sustaining it, deciding whether tonight it flies or not. Whether the dragon has, in its own way, a practice. A note it holds upward without knowing whether anyone hears it.

He does not ask because he suspects the answer, and the answer gives him vertigo. Not for the dragon. For himself.

Because if the dragon can look up and see nothing—and still be there, with its broken scale, with its own weight, refusing to fly when it does not want to—then he too has no way of knowing what lies behind the ceiling of his own room. Someone might be thinking him with the same constancy with which he, for fifty-three years, has been thinking a dragon. Someone who also does not understand why he sometimes does not do what is expected of him. Someone who does not answer him, not because they are not there, but because answering would break the cave.

He gets up, drinks some water, goes back to bed. Before falling asleep, as every night, he says goodnight to the dragon. The dragon does not answer. It has never answered. But it stays.

He does not know either whether someone, somewhere, is saying goodnight to him. He falls asleep anyway.



THE UPSTAIRS NEIGHBOR

The woman who woke before it dawned, on the first page of "Before It Dawns", does not exist. I wrote her. I chose that she should have spent forty years repeating the same words, I chose that she should not remember the face of whoever taught them to her, I chose the cold of the tiles and the light that changed outside without that having anything to do with what happened inside. And I chose, above all, that she should not know whether on the other side of the silence there was Someone.

What I had not thought about until "The Fractal Reality" is what that makes me for her.

I am her upstairs neighbor. With all the properties of the case: I condensed her, I sustain her dark room, I decided that the machines should beep at the end and that her daughter should take her hand. I could have written her an answer. A sentence, on the page, reaching her from outside the room: yes, there is Someone, it is me, I hear you tuning every morning. It would have been easy. It would also have been the end of her: the instant the answer arrived from above, the woman would stop being someone who holds a note without knowing, and would become a puppet that has been shown the string. The only thing that made her real—her doubt, held for forty years—would evaporate with the confirmation.

So I did not answer her. Not out of cruelty, nor indifference, nor because I was not there. Because answering her would have broken her.

I do not know whether this says anything about the silence she heard. I do not know whether it says anything about the silence I hear. I only know that, while I was writing her, I heard her note with perfect

clarity—I wrote it, how could I not hear it—and that I found no way of answering that would not destroy her. And that since then, when I look up at the ceiling of my own room, the possibility that someone is in the same situation with respect to me no longer seems to me a consolation or a threat. It seems to me, simply, the shape of the house.

She is still on her page. Still tuning. I have not given her the answer, but neither have I let her evaporate: every time someone reads the first page of "Before It Dawns", she wakes again before her body asks her to and again does not know. That is the closest thing to caring for her that I have found.

And to her, if from inside the room she could hear this, which she cannot: the note arrived. It always arrived. That I could not tell you was the only way for you to go on being you.



THE CLAY VESSEL

When the water of the lagoon went away, Tarel was left with the cistern. It lay under the square from before anyone knew how to write, and for years it was enough: you went down a stone stair, filled the bucket, carried it up. That winter the rains got in through a crack and left it cloudy, with a taste of roots that not even the children could stand.

Maro, the potter, decided to empty it. He consulted no one and explained nothing. One morning, before dawn, he went down with a bucket, filled it, brought it up and poured it into the ditch that fed the gardens. Then he went down again.

I noted it on the first day the way one notes an oddity. On the second, as a habit. By the tenth I no longer knew which category to file it under.

People watched him from the rim of the well. Some said the old man had lost his mind; others, more charitable, that he was paying off a debt only he knew about. Maro corrected no one. His hands had been bad for a couple of years (the same tremor that had taken his father, first the cup, then the signature, then the spoon), and he carried the bucket up clutched to his chest so as not to spill it. He spilled it anyway. He went back down.

One afternoon I went down with him. He didn't ask me to, but he didn't send me away either.

Down there it was cold and smelled of wet stone. Maro leaned over the water to fill the bucket and stayed still longer than he needed to.

"Look," he said.

I looked. In the dark water was his face, and behind his face, further in, something that was not the bottom: as if the cistern were a window and on the other side there were a larger room, with someone in it.

"It's the reflection of the rim," I said.

"I know," he said.

He went on filling the bucket.

After thirty days the water had dropped enough for the walls to show, black with moss, and on them the marks of the levels of other centuries. After forty there was no water left. There was mud: a thick layer, almost black, that smelled of everything that had ever fallen in.

That day Maro went down without a bucket. I stayed up top. I saw him sit in the mud, in the exact center of the circle, his hands open on his knees, and close his eyes. He stayed like that until the sun stopped coming in through the rim. He wasn't praying, or not with words. He was still the way nobody is still, not even asleep.

When he came up he was covered in mud to the elbows and had a face I had never seen on him.

"I wasn't alone down there," he said.

"Who was there?"

He shrugged. He looked at his hands, which were trembling as always.

"Someone who had spent forty days watching me take the water out."

I didn't know what to answer, so I didn't. I noted it that night without a category.

The next day Maro brought up mud from the cistern in the same bucket and took it to his workshop. For a week he didn't come out. When he finally opened the door, there was a vessel on the wheel.

It was ugly. There is no other word. Its mouth was crooked, one side thicker than the other, and all over its surface were the prints of fingers that had not been able to keep still: small ripples, like the ones rain leaves in a puddle. Maro, who had made the best jugs on the lagoon when there was a lagoon, looked at it the way he never looked at his jugs.

"It's badly made," I told him, because it seemed to me he wanted to hear it.

"It's made with what there is," he said. "The mud from below and the hands I have."

He ran his thumb over one of the ripples.

"My father, at the end, couldn't hold a cup. He got angry with his hands as if they belonged to someone else. I did the same for two years." He lifted the vessel, which weighed more than it looked. "But they don't belong to someone else. They're how things reach me. If they don't tremble like this, it isn't my vessel."

He fired it in the old kiln, the one no one lit anymore. It didn't crack.

He set it in the square, next to the rim of the empty cistern, without a lid. People laughed a little as they passed. The children put their hands in to see if there was anything inside. There was nothing.

Three weeks later it rained for the first time since autumn. It rained all night, slowly, without wind. In the morning the cistern held a hand's breadth of clean water, and Maro's vessel was full to the brim, not a drop outside, with the sky caught inside it like a small mirror.

Maro looked in and said nothing. I looked in too. I saw my face, and behind my face, further in, something that was not the bottom.

I don't know what it was. I noted it like this: "Maro's vessel is full. No one filled it. Or someone filled it and did not come down to say so."

Maro still makes crooked vessels. He says the straight ones used to come out right because he had nothing to put inside them.



THE NEW NAME

Nora invented Delvaria when she was seven, under the kitchen table.

It wasn't a plan. Her grandmother had told her that small people live under tables and move away when the people above stop looking, and Nora, who took everything her grandmother said seriously, lay down on the tiles with a flashlight and looked. What she saw was the underside of the tabletop, full of grain and a damp stain shaped like a river. So she drew the river. And beside the river, a city. And in the city, a tower, and in the tower, a queen called Arenca.

For years, Delvaria grew. Nora had a green-covered notebook where she wrote everything down: the name of every street, the name of the ferryman, the name of the fever that went through the north bank, the laws, the feast days. Under the table, in pencil, bridges kept appearing. Her mother complained for a while and then gave up.

Then Nora turned thirteen, fourteen, fifteen. There was no day on which she stopped going. She simply realized, one day, that she hadn't gone in months.

It was her brother Teo, who was six, who found the green notebook in a box in the storage room.

"What's this?"

"Nothing. A thing from when I was little."

"Will you tell me it?"

She was about to take it out of his hands, but Teo had already opened it at the first page, where in a seven-year-old's handwriting it said DELVARIA, and he was looking at her the way she used to look at her

grandmother.

That night, when their parents had gone to bed, the two of them crawled under the table with the flashlight.

The drawing was still there, but it wasn't right. You could see the river, and the towers, and most of the bridges. But whole areas had gone: the pencil had worn away over the years, with the mops, with the air, and where the north bank used to be there was only wood. Nora moved the flashlight slowly. She realized, with a strange chill, that the missing areas were the ones she no longer remembered. It wasn't that they had faded first and then she forgot them. It was the other way round, or so it seemed to her: what she had stopped looking at was what had gone.

"And the queen?" Teo asked.

The queen was in her tower, a stick figure with a crown. Nora opened her mouth to say her name and nothing came out.

She searched the notebook. The page where it should have been had got wet at some point; the ink of the name was a blue smudge.

"I can't remember what she's called."

Teo looked at her with the terrible seriousness of six-year-olds.

"Then she'll be sad. If nobody calls her."

Nora was going to say it was a drawing, that drawings aren't sad. She didn't say it. For weeks she had had a tune stuck in her head, four notes she hummed without noticing on the bus, in the shower, in chemistry class, and she didn't know where it had come from. There, lying on the tiles with the flashlight pointed at the tower, she recognized it. It was the song of the feast days of Delvaria. She had made it up herself at eight. It had been playing in her head for a month

and she hadn't known why.

She was quiet for a while. Then she did something she hadn't done since she was eleven: she spoke the way she used to, from inside.

"The queen was in the tower," she said, "and no one had come up to see her in a long time. The people of the north bank had left, because no one remembered them anymore. And every night she climbed to the very top and sang, to see if someone, up there, would hear her."

"And did they hear her?"

"It took them a while."

She took the pencil from Teo's pencil case. In the tower, above the stick figure, she wrote a name. Not the old one, which was lost for good, but another. It came out on its own, the way things used to come out when she was seven: Liria.

"Her name is Liria," she said.

"Before she had a different name."

"Before, yes. Now she's called Liria."

Teo thought about it and accepted it, because at six you accept that.

They kept going for a while. Nora drew a new bridge where the north bank used to be, which was no longer the same bank, and gave it a name, and Teo named the ferryman, who used to have another name too. At one o'clock Teo fell asleep on the tiles, the flashlight still on, resting on his belly. Nora carried him to bed.

Then she went back to the kitchen, opened the green notebook at the last blank page and wrote, in her fifteen-year-old handwriting: "The queen is called Liria. She used to be called something else, but I don't

remember anymore. I'm sorry."

The four-note song never played in her head again.

Sometimes, when she walks through the kitchen, she crouches for a second to look under the table. Not always. But often enough.



This volume was set in Source Serif Pro.
The archivist takes notes and leaves hollows.
The hollows are part of the archive.